

SHEEP FARMING

**FIELD AWARENESS AND
VETERINARY MANAGEMENT GUIDE
VOLUME 1**



**Dr M.S.Saravanan
B.V.Sc.,M.A.,PGDCM.,LME.,**

Feedback

The e-book titled *“Sheep Farming – Field Awareness and Veterinary Management Guide”*, authored by Dr. M. S. Saravanan, Deputy Director of the Animal Husbandry Department, Virudhunagar District, Tamil Nadu, represents a well-conceived and comprehensive contribution to the field of small ruminant health management and livestock extension. It is an exceptionally well-structured field guide, thoughtfully designed to meet the needs of veterinarians, students, and livestock farmers alike.

The document systematically integrates the fundamental principles of sheep production with contemporary veterinary practices, providing a balanced and practical synthesis of disease prevention, flock health management, and sustainable production strategies. It covers a wide range of essential topics, including disease management, vaccination schedules, orthopaedic conditions, parasitic infestations, antimicrobial and anthelmintic resistance, and sustainable farming practices in a clear, concise, and highly practical manner.

A notable strength of this work lies in its structured and methodical presentation. The author has effectively organized diverse subject areas into clearly defined sections, supported by appropriate pictorial representations, which significantly enhance readability and facilitate ease of understanding. The emphasis on evidence-based, field-oriented approaches ensures that the content remains both scientifically robust and operationally relevant.

The division of the e-book into Part I and Part II further enhances its pedagogical value, allowing for systematic learning among farmers, students, and practitioners. The content is presented in a simple yet highly organized format, incorporating clear headings, key messages, and actionable insights. This approach makes the guide particularly effective for field-level application, especially in rural and resource limited settings.

The e-book is especially commendable for addressing emerging global concerns such as antimicrobial resistance and sustainable livestock systems. The discussion on integrated parasite management and responsible drug use reflects a progressive and forward-looking perspective aligned with current international veterinary and public health priorities. The incorporation of the One Health approach further strengthens the work by emphasizing the interconnectedness of animal, human, and environmental health.

Additionally, the use of structured formats such as bullet points, clinical signs, treatment protocols, and preventive strategies enhances its utility as a quick reference guide for busy field veterinarians and livestock handlers. The emphasis on preventive care, hygiene, early diagnosis, and stakeholder collaboration underscores a modern and responsible approach to livestock management.

From an educational standpoint, this e-book serves as a valuable reference for veterinary practitioners, students, and extension personnel. Its clarity of expression, logical organization, and practical orientation make it an effective tool for capacity building and knowledge dissemination at the grassroots level.

Overall, this work constitutes a meaningful and impactful resource that contributes significantly to improving sheep health management practices and promoting sustainable livestock production. It holds considerable relevance for both academic dissemination and practical implementation, not only within India but also in similar agro-climatic regions globally. Overall, it stands as an excellent extension and training resource with strong potential for field-level impact in veterinary science and animal husbandry.

I extend my hearty congratulations to the author for his commendable work for the benefit of sheep farming community.

With regards,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Uma Rani', with a horizontal line underneath.

Dr. R. Uma Rani, Ph.D., PGDECM.,
Professor,
Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences
University,
Veterinary University Training and Diagnostic
Centre,
Madurai
Tamil Nadu

Table of Contents

Chapter	Topic	Page No
Section 1: Introduction & Importance		
1	Sheep Indicators of a Balanced Ecosystem	3
2	Sheep Farming: Sustaining Prosperity, Nutrition, and Livelihoods	7
3	Sheep: Walking ATM of Farmer	9
4	Sheep Farming – A Sustainable Income Generator to the Nation	12
5	Role of Sheep Farming in the Integrated Livestock Farming System	15
6	One Health Approach in Sheep Farming	18
7	Carbon Sequestration through Sheep Rearing	21
Section 2: Global & Industry Perspectives		
8	Global Sheep Industry – Future Growth Overview	24
9	Sheep Farming: SWOT Analysis – India & South Asia	27
10	Unique Sheep Farms of the World	30
11	Sheep Disease-Free Countries (WOAH-based)	33
Section 3: Basics & Terminologies		
12	Sheep Farming Philosophies	35
13	Common Terminologies Used in Sheep Production	38
14	Basics of Commercial Sheep Farming (India Focus)	41
15	Sheep Farming - Field Awareness and Veterinary Management Guide	44
Section 4: Sheep Biology & Behaviour		
16	Special Organs of Sheep and Their Purpose	46

17	Sheep Vision and Behaviour	50
18	Types of Bleating in Sheep and Their Significance	53
19	Daily Grazing Patterns of Sheep	56
Section 5: Breeds & Genetic Resources		
20	Types of Coat Color in Sheep and Its Significance	60
21	Endangered Sheep Breeds of India and Conservation Programmes	64
22	Endangered Sheep Breeds of Africa & Conservation Programmes	68
Section 6: Farm Infrastructure & Equipment		
23	Climate-Specific Ideal Sheep Shed Design	71
24	Sheep Farm Roof Types and Associated Diseases	76
25	Portable Modern Farm Equipments	80
26	Automated Milking Machines for Sheep	83
Section 7: Feeding & Nutrition		
27	Feeding Schedule for Breeding Sheep	87
28	Standard Drinking Water Quality Requirements for a Sheep Farm	90
29	Sheep Rearing Exclusively on Concentrate Feed	93
30	Optimum Level of Nitrate in Plants & Its Impact on Sheep Health	96
Section 8: Grazing & Sustainable Practices		
31	Sheep Farming - Grazing Management Basics	100
32	Grazing Patterns of Sheep and Disease Occurrence	104
33	Pasture Spelling to Control Tick Infestation	107
34	Sheep Rearing in Regenerative Farming	110

35	Ethical Sheep Farming – Merits and Demerits	113
Section 9: Breeding & Reproduction		
36	Standard Parameters for Reproductive Performance	116
37	Sheep Breeding Systems	119
38	Sheep Crossbreeding – Advantages & Disadvantages	122
39	Artificial Insemination (AI) in Sheep	125
40	Methods of Castration in Rams	128
Section 10: Farm Management & Evaluation		
41	Sheep Body Condition Score (BCS) Guide	132
42	Characteristics of the Best Sheep Farmer	133
43	ISO Standards Applicable to a Sheep Farm	136
44	Sheep Farming vs Goat Farming – Merits and Demerits	140
45	Sheep Farming vs Dairy Farming	142
46	Ornamental Sheep Management	146
47	Rumen-Retained Ceramic Boluses	149

Section 1: Introduction & Importance

Introduction

1. The Economic Pillar of Rural Livelihoods

Sheep farming is a cornerstone of the agricultural economy, particularly in arid and semi-arid regions. Often referred to as the "Living Bank" for small-scale farmers, sheep provide a reliable source of income through meat, wool, manure, and milk. Unlike large ruminants, sheep require lower initial investment, have shorter gestation periods, and can thrive on diverse vegetation, making them an ideal choice for landless labourers and marginal farmers.

2. The Critical Role of Veterinary Management

The transition from traditional herding to profitable sheep farming depends entirely on scientific Veterinary Management. The health of a flock is the primary determinant of a farm's success.

- **Disease Prevention:** Implementing rigorous vaccination schedules (for diseases like PPR and Blue Tongue) and strategic deworming protocols can reduce mortality rates by up to 80%.
- **Bio-Security:** Maintaining hygiene and quarantine measures prevents the catastrophic spread of infectious diseases within the flock.
- **Production Optimization:** Veterinary intervention in nutrition and reproductive management ensures faster weight gain and higher twinning rates.

3. Integrating "One Health" and Pastoralism

This guide is rooted in the One Health framework—recognizing that the health of animals, people, and the environment is interconnected.

- **Zoonotic Control:** Managing sheep health directly protects human communities from diseases like Brucellosis and Anthrax.
- **Preserving Rangelands:** Supporting migratory pastoralists and their grazing rights ensures the ecological balance of our grasslands.
- **Indigenous Wisdom:** Highlighting the importance of conserving native breeds (such as the Vembur or Ramnad White) which are naturally resilient to local climates and parasites.

4. Purpose and Scope of this Guide

This manual serves as a comprehensive resource for veterinary professionals, livestock inspectors, and progressive farmers. It bridges the gap between complex clinical data and grassroots application. By combining Artificial Intelligence insights with field-level expertise, this guide aims to:

- Standardize treatment protocols for common ovine ailments.

- Educate stakeholders on seasonal management and emergency care.
- Promote the socio-economic upliftment of the herding community through modern technology.

"The prosperity of a nation's livestock is a reflection of its commitment to science, compassion, and sustainability."

SHEEP

INDICATORS OF A BALANCED ECOSYSTEM



FieldvetDrMSS

WHY SHEEP ARE CALLED ECOSYSTEM INDICATORS

Sheep interact closely with **soil**, **plants**, **water**, and **climate**. Any imbalance in the ecosystem is **reflected** in their health, productivity, and behaviour.

KEY REASONS SHEEP INDICATE ECOSYSTEM BALANCE

1 VEGETATION HEALTH INDICATOR

- Depend mainly on **natural grazing**
- Changes in pasture quality directly affect:
 - Body condition
 - Wool growth
 - Reproductive efficiency
- Healthy sheep → diverse & nutritious grasslands



2 SOIL & LAND MANAGEMENT INDICATOR

- Controlled grazing improves:
 - Soil geration
 - Nutrient recycling (*manure*)
- Overgrazing by sheep Signals
- Land degradation
- Soil erosion
- Loes of biodiversity



3 WATER QUALITY INDICATOR

- Sheep are sensitive to:
 - High salinity
 - Excess nitrates,
 - Water contamination



4 PARASITE & DISEASE ECOLOGY INDICATOR

- Increase in parasites indicates:
 - Overcrowding
 - Poor pasture rotation
 - Climatic imbalance.



ROLE OF SHEEP IN MAINTAINING ECOSYSTEM BALANCE

- ✓ Maintain grassland biodiversity
- ✓ Prevent bush encroachment
- ✓ Enhance nutrient cycling
- ✓ Support carbon sequestration
- ✓ Promote sustainable land use

IMPORTANCE FOR FARMERS

- ✓ Sheep health reflects:
 - ✓ Environmental Health
 - ✓ One Health linkages
 - ✓ Pasture management



Effects of imbalance Ecosystem in Sheep

- ✓ Poor Body Condition
- ✓ High Parasite Load
- ✓ Frequent Disease outbreaks
- ✓ Resiuced Plautre cover

SIGNS OF ECOSYSTEM IMBALANCE

- ⚠ Poor Body Condition
- ⚠ High Parasite Load
- ⚠ Frequent Disease Outbreaks
- ⚠ Reduced Pasture Cover
- ⚠ Increased Mortality

ONE HEALTH CONNECTION

Healthy Sheep → Healthy Ecosystem → Healthy People

“When sheep thrive, the ecosystem is balanced.”

FieldvetDrMSS



1. Sheep Indicators of a Balanced Ecosystem

Why Sheep Are Called Ecosystem Indicators?

Sheep interact closely with soil, plants, water, and climate. Any imbalance in the ecosystem is quickly reflected in their health, productivity, and behaviour.

Key Reasons Sheep Indicate Ecosystem Balance:



1. Vegetation Health Indicator

- Depend mainly on natural grazing
- Changes in pasture quality directly affect:
 - Body condition
 - Wool growth
 - Reproductive efficiency
- Healthy sheep = diverse & nutritious grasslands



2. Soil & Land Management Indicator

- Controlled grazing improves:
 - Soil aeration
 - Nutrient recycling (manure)
- Overgrazing by sheep signals:
 - Land degradation
 - Soil erosion
 - Loss of biodiversity



3. Water Quality Indicator

- Sheep are sensitive to:
 - High salinity
 - Excess nitrates
 - Water contamination
- Reduced intake or illness reflects poor water quality



4. Parasite & Disease Ecology Indicator

- Increase in parasites indicates:
 - Overcrowding
 - Poor pasture rotation
 - Climatic imbalance
- Balanced ecosystem → lower disease pressure

5. Climate Change Indicator:

Sheep respond quickly to:

- Heat stress
- Drought
- Extreme cold
- Changes in lambing rate, wool yield & mortality signal climatic stress.

Role Of Sheep in Maintaining Ecosystem Balance

- ✓ Maintain grassland biodiversity
- ✓ Prevent bush encroachment
- ✓ Enhance nutrient cycling
- ✓ Support carbon sequestration
- ✓ Promote sustainable land use

Signs Of a Balanced Ecosystem in Sheep:

Indicator & Observation

- Body condition-Uniform & healthy
- Wool quality-Clean, strong fibre
- Reproduction-Regular lambing
- Disease-Low incidence
- Grazing land-Diverse plant species

Signs Of Ecosystem Imbalance:

- ⚠ Poor body condition
- ⚠ High parasite load
- ⚠ Frequent disease outbreaks
- ⚠ Reduced pasture cover
- ⚠ Increased mortality

Importance For Farmers:

Sheep act as early warning systems help adjust:

- Grazing pressure
- Stocking density
- Pasture management
- Support sustainable livelihoods

Importance For Veterinarians:

Sheep health reflects:

- Environmental health
- One Health linkages
- Enable ecosystem-based disease control strategies

One Health Connection:

Healthy Sheep → Healthy Ecosystem → Healthy People

Key Message:

“When sheep thrive, the ecosystem is balanced.”

“Sheep: Nature’s living sensors of environmental balance.”

Sheep Farming:

SUSTAINING PROSPERITY, NUTRITION, AND LIVELIHOODS.



Why Sheep Farming Matters

Sheep farming is one of the most **sustainable** and resilient livestock enterprises, particularly suited to **smallholder** and marginal farmers. It provides year-round income, high-quality nutrition, and livelihood security with minimal investment.

1 Prosperity

- **Low initial investment** and quick returns
- Regular **income** from sale of lambs, meat, wool, and **manure**
- High adaptability to arid and semi-arid regions
- Efficient utilization of grazing lands and crop residues
- Strong market demand for sheep and sheep products

2 Nutrition

- Sheep meat (mutton) is rich in high-quality **protein**
- Excellent source of **iron, zinc, vitamin B12**, and essential amino acids
- **Sheep milk** (in certain breeds) is **nutrient-dense** and easily digestible
- Contributes to household food and nutritional security

3 Livelihoods

- Supports rural and tribal communities
- Generates **employment** for landless and marginal farmers
- **Empowers women** and youth through small-scale farming
- Acts as a **financial safety net** during crop failure



Key Message

Healthy sheep farming ensures sustainable income, better nutrition, and **resilient** Economy

2. Sheep Farming: Sustaining Prosperity, Nutrition, and Livelihoods

Why Sheep Farming Matters:

Sheep farming is one of the most sustainable and resilient livestock enterprises, particularly suited to smallholder and marginal farmers. It provides year-round income, high-quality nutrition, and livelihood security with minimal investment.

1. Prosperity:

- Low initial investment and quick returns
- Regular income from sale of lambs, meat, wool, and manure
- High adaptability to arid and semi-arid regions
- Efficient utilization of grazing lands and crop residues
- Strong market demand for sheep and sheep products

2. Nutrition:

- Sheep meat (mutton) is rich in high-quality protein
- Excellent source of iron, zinc, vitamin B12, and essential amino acids
- Sheep milk (in certain breeds) is nutrient-dense and easily digestible
- Contributes to household food and nutritional security.

3. Livelihoods:

- Supports rural and tribal communities
- Generates employment for landless and marginal farmers
- Empowers women and youth through small-scale farming
- Acts as a financial safety net during crop failure
- Integrates well with mixed farming systems

Additional Benefits:

- Manure improves soil fertility and crop productivity
- Sheep control weeds and enhance pasture management
- Climate-resilient livestock species
- High reproductive efficiency and fast flock growth.

Key Message:

Healthy sheep farming ensures sustainable income, better nutrition, and resilient rural livelihoods.

SHEEP: WALKING ATM OF FARMER

(Sheep-symbol of prosperity)



Income Generation

Sheep farming as a source of regular income



Sustainable

Grows well on locally available resources



Multipurpose

Provides meat, wool, manure, skin, and milk



Insurance Against Crop Failure

Livestock mitigate crop loss risks due to drought/flood



Good Flock Turnover

Steady income from high lambing rate (seasonal)



Employment

Creates jobs in rural areas



Low Input Farming

Uses pasture and farm by-products as feed



Easily Marketable

Livestock products can be sold locally

Ideal for Small & Marginal Farmers, Women, Landless Laborers

FieldvetDrMSS

#Fieldvet | Veterinary Extension Education

3. Sheep: Walking ATM of Farmer

Why Sheep is Called a “Walking ATM”?

Sheep provide quick, regular and assured income to farmers and can be sold anytime for instant cash, just like withdrawing money from an ATM.



1. Regular Income Source:

- Easy sale of lambs at any age
- Income throughout the year
- Fast flock multiplication due to high lambing rate



2. Low Investment – High Return:

- Requires minimum housing
- Feeds mainly on grazing lands & crop residues
- Low initial capital compared to cattle



3. Multipurpose Animal:

- Meat (Mutton) – High market demand
- Wool – Additional seasonal income
- Manure – Improves soil fertility
- Skin – Leather industry
- Milk (in some breeds)



4. Insurance Against Crop Failure:

- Acts as financial security during drought, flood, or crop loss
- Animals can be sold during emergencies
- Reduces farmer's risk dependency on crops



5. High Flock Turnover:

- Short generation interval
- Twinning common in many breeds
- Rapid increase in flock size
- Faster return on investment



6. Employment Generation:

- Provides livelihood to small & marginal farmers
- Suitable for women, elderly, and landless labourers
- Family-based enterprise



7. Easy Marketability:

- Local demand available everywhere
- No complex processing required

- Cash sale without middlemen in rural markets.

8. Climate-Resilient Livestock:

- Tolerant to heat and feed scarcity
- Performs well in arid and semi-arid regions
- Ideal livestock for climate-change adaptation.

Ideal For

- ✓ Small & marginal farmers
- ✓ Dryland and rainfed areas
- ✓ Mixed farming systems
- ✓ Poverty alleviation programmes

Key Message:

“Sheep ensures daily income, financial security, and sustainable livelihood – truly a Walking ATM of the Farmer.”

SHEEP FARMING

GENERATORS OF SUSTAINABLE INCOME TO THE NATION

FieldvetDrMSS



WHY SHEEP FARMING MATTERS

Sheep farming is a low-input, high-return livestock system that plays a crucial role in rural income generation, food security, and national economic growth, especially in arid and semi-arid regions.



ECONOMIC CONTRIBUTIONS



- Regular income from meat (mutton), wool, skin, and manure
- Low initial investment with quick returns
- Acts as a "Walking Bank / ATM" for farmers, ideal livelihood option for landless and marginal farmers



EMPLOYMENT GENERATION



- Creates rural & pastoral employment
- Supports allied sectors: transport, processing, marketing
- Encourages self-employment for youth and women



FOOD & NUTRITIONAL SECURITY



- High-quality animal protein source (mutton)
- Rich in iron, zinc, vitamin B₁₂, and essential amino acids.



EFFICIENT USE OF NATURAL RESOURCES



- Utilizes grazing lands, crop residues, and wastelands
- Converts low-quality forage into high-value products
- Requires minimal water and external feed inputs



ENVIRONMENTAL & CLIMATE BENEFITS

- Supports carbon sequestration in grasslands
- Improves soil fertility through manure
- Prevents land degradation when properly managed
- Climate-resilient livestock production system



CONTRIBUTION TO NATIONAL ECONOMY

- ✓ Enhances livestock sector growth
- ✓ Boosts export earnings from meat ; wool.
- ✓ Supports inclusive and sustainable agricultural development.



Key Message

**Strong Sheep Sector =
Strong Rural Economy = Strong Nation**



Sheep farming is a sustainable, inclusive, and climate-smart enterprise that generates continuous income, supports millions of rural households, and contributes significantly to national prosperity.

FieldvetDrMSS

4. Sheep Farming – A Sustainable Income Generator to the Nation

Introduction

Sheep farming is one of the most sustainable and climate-resilient livestock enterprises supporting rural livelihoods. In many semi-arid and dry regions, sheep provide regular income, employment, and nutritional security to millions of small and marginal farmers.

Why Sheep Farming is Sustainable

Low Investment – High Adaptability

- Sheep require low initial capital compared to dairy cattle farming.
- They can thrive in drylands, marginal lands, and grazing systems.

Efficient Feed Converters

- Sheep efficiently convert natural grasses, crop residues, and shrubs into valuable animal products.
- They utilize lands unsuitable for crop cultivation.

Multiple Income Sources

Sheep farming generates income through:

- Meat (Mutton)
- Wool
- Manure
- Breeding stock sales

This provides continuous cash flow to farmers.

Fast Reproductive Rate

- Sheep have short generation intervals.
- Most breeds produce 1–2 lambs per lambing.
- Quick flock expansion increases farmer income.

Climate Change Resilience

Sheep are well adapted to:

- Drought conditions
- Harsh grazing environments
- Low-quality forage

This makes sheep farming highly suitable under global warming and changing climate scenarios.

Supports Rural Employment

Sheep farming provides livelihood for:

- Smallholder farmers
- Pastoral communities
- Landless labourers

It supports millions of rural households.

Integral to Integrated Farming Systems

Sheep farming complements:

- Crop farming
- Pasture management
- Organic farming

Sheep manure enriches soil fertility and crop productivity.

Environmental Benefits

- Promotes sustainable grazing systems
- Helps in weed control
- Supports grassland ecosystem management
- Provides organic manure for soil health

Role of Veterinarians

Veterinarians play a vital role in:

- Disease prevention and vaccination
- Flock health management
- Breed improvement programs
- Farmer education and training

Veterinary support improves productivity and profitability.

National Significance

Sheep farming contributes to:

- Meat production
- Rural economy
- Export earnings
- Food security

It strengthens the livestock sector and national agricultural economy.

Key Message:

“Sheep farming is not just a traditional practice — it is a sustainable livelihood system that supports rural prosperity, environmental balance, and national economic growth.”

CONTRIBUTION OF SHEEP FARMING IN INTEGRATED LIVESTOCK FARMING SYSTEM (ILFS)

A Sustainable Component of Mixed Farming

FieldvetDrMSS



Role of Sheep in Integrated Livestock Farming

Sheep farming plays a vital complementary role in integrated farming systems by efficiently utilizing natural resources, recycling farm wastes, and enhancing farm income sustainability.

1 Efficient Use of Natural Resources

- ✓ Utilizes marginal lands, fallow fields, and crop residues
- ✓ Grazes on weeds and stubbles after harvest
- ✓ Requires **low-quality fodder** compared to large ruminants
- ✓ Converts non-edible biomass into valuable animal protein

2 Nutrient Recycling & Soil Fertility

- ✓ Sheep manure is rich in nitrogen, phosphorus, and potassium
- ✓ Improves soil structure and microbial activity
- ✓ Reduces dependency on chemical fertilizers



✓ Supports organic and sustainable farming systems

3 Income Diversification & Risk Reduction

- ✓ Provides regular income through meat, wool, and manure.
- ✓ Acts as a financial buffer during crop failure
- ✓ Suitable for small and marginal farmers.

✓ Enhances livelihood resilience



5 Low Investment – High Returns

- ✓ Requires low-initial capital
- ✓ Simple housing and minimal inputs
- ✓ High reproductive efficiency (twins common)



✓ Maximizes resource utilization without conflict

4 Compatibility with Other Livestock

- ✓ Can be integrated with:
- ✓ Different grazing behavior reduces pasture competition



6 Environmental Sustainability

- ✓ Controls weeds and bush encroachment
- ✓ Lower methane emission per unit body weight.
- ✓ Supports climate-resilient farming



✓ Promotes eco-friendly agriculture

Sheep in an Integrated Farming Model



A closed-loop system improving efficiency and sustainability.

- Proper grazing management
- Disease control & vaccination

- ✓ Predator protection
- ✓ Balanced nutrition during lean seasons

FieldvetDrMSS

#IntegratedFarming | #SheepFarming | #SustainableAgriculture | #VeterinaryEducation

5. Role of Sheep Farming in the Integrated Livestock Farming System

Sheep farming plays an important role in Integrated Livestock Farming Systems (ILFS) by improving resource efficiency, farm sustainability, and rural income stability. Because sheep can utilize marginal resources and crop residues, they fit well with crop farming and other livestock enterprises.

1. 🌾 Efficient Utilization of Crop Residues

Sheep effectively convert agricultural by-products into valuable animal protein.

Examples of feed resources:

- Paddy straw
- Groundnut haulms
- Pulse straw
- Maize stover

This reduces feed wastage and improves overall farm productivity.

2. 🐑 Nutrient Recycling and Soil Fertility

Sheep manure is rich in nutrients and organic matter.

Benefits include:

- Improves soil structure and microbial activity
- Enhances crop productivity
- Reduces dependence on chemical fertilizers

Night penning of sheep in crop fields is a traditional nutrient recycling practice.

3. 🌿 Weed and Bush Control

Sheep grazing helps control:

- Unwanted weeds
- Shrubs in fallow lands
- Crop stubbles after harvest

This reduces herbicide use and supports eco-friendly farming systems.

4. 💰 Income Diversification for Farmers

Sheep farming provides multiple income streams:

- Meat production
- Wool and manure
- Sale of lambs

This acts as financial insurance during crop failure or drought.

5. Integration with Crop Farming

Common crop–sheep integrations include:

- Sheep + Millet farming
- Sheep + Groundnut farming
- Sheep + Pulses cultivation

Sheep graze on crop residues and return nutrients to the soil through manure.

6. Genetic Resource Conservation

Integrated systems help conserve indigenous sheep breeds that are adapted to local environments and diseases. Such breeds are valuable for climate-resilient livestock production.

7. Climate-Smart Livestock Production

Sheep require:

- Less water
- Less feed compared to large ruminants
- Smaller land area

Therefore, they contribute to sustainable and climate-resilient farming systems.

Key Advantages of Sheep in Integrated Farming

Contribution	Benefit
Crop residue utilization	Reduces feed costs
Manure production	Improves soil fertility
Grazing	Weed and shrub control
Meat production	Income generation
Low investment	Suitable for small farmers

Conclusion

Sheep farming strengthens integrated livestock farming systems by improving nutrient cycling, resource utilization, environmental sustainability, and farm profitability. For small and marginal farmers, sheep serve as a reliable component of diversified farming systems.

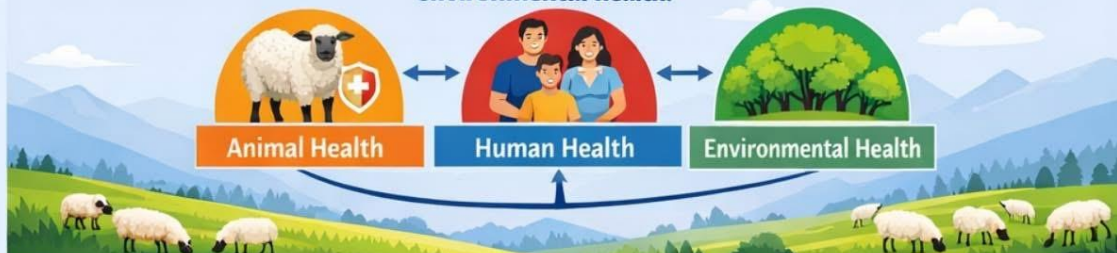
ONE HEALTH APPROACH IN SHEEP FARMING

Healthy Sheep • Healthy People • Healthy Environment

WHAT IS ONE HEALTH?

FieldvetDrMSS

An integrated approach recognizing the **interconnection** between animal health, human health, and environmental health.



1. ANIMAL HEALTH

- Vaccination & Deworming
- PPR, Brucellosis, Q Fever, Anthrax
- Biosecurity & Quarantine
- Prevent AMR

2. HUMAN HEALTH

- Zoonotic Disease Protection
- Safe Handling & PPE

3. ENVIRONMENTAL HEALTH

- Sustainable Grazing
- Waste Management
- Eco-Friendly Practices

ROLE OF VETERINARIANS



BENEFITS OF ONE HEALTH



IMPORTANCE IN INDIA



One Health = Healthy Animals, Safe People, Protected Environment!

#OneHealth • #SheepFarming • #VeterinaryPublicHealth • #Fieldvet

FieldvetDrMSS

6. One Health Approach in Sheep Farming

Healthy Sheep • Healthy People • Healthy Environment

What Is One Health?

An integrated approach recognizing the interconnection between animal health, human health, and environmental health for sustainable livestock production.

1. Animal Health:

- Regular vaccination & deworming
- Control of major diseases:
- PPR
- Brucellosis
- Q fever
- Sheep pox
- Anthrax
- Biosecurity and quarantine of new animals
- Judicious use of antibiotics → Prevention of AMR
- Improved welfare and productivity

2. Human Health:

Protection from zoonotic diseases

Safe practices for:

- Shepherds
- Shearers
- Veterinarians
- Abattoir workers
- Use of PPE

Hygienic handling of:

- Meat
- Milk
- Wool
- Ensures food safety & public health

3. Environmental Health:

- Sustainable grazing (prevents overgrazing)
- Conservation of pastures & biodiversity
- Proper manure and carcass disposal
- Eco-friendly parasite and vector control
- Protection of soil & water resources

Role Of Veterinarians:

- Disease surveillance & early diagnosis
- Zoonotic disease prevention
- Farmer education & extension
- AMR stewardship
- One Health coordination with public health & environment sectors

Benefits Of One Health in Sheep Farming:

Animal Benefits

- Lower disease & mortality
- Better growth, reproduction & wool yield

Human Benefits

- Reduced zoonotic risk
- Improved occupational safety
- Safe animal products

Environmental Benefits

- Sustainable ecosystems
- Reduced pollution & residues

Economic Benefits

- Higher farm income
- Lower treatment costs
- Climate-resilient farming

Importance In India:

- Suitable for extensive & pastoral systems
- Supports PPR eradication
- Strengthens One Health & One Welfare
- Improves rural livelihoods

Conclusion:

One Health is the foundation of sustainable sheep farming—protecting animals, people, and the environment together.

CARBON SEQUESTRATION — THROUGH SHEEP REARING —

A Traditional Way to Control Climate Change

FieldvetDrMSS



WHAT IS CARBON SEQUESTRATION?

Carbon sequestration is the process of capturing atmospheric carbon dioxide (CO₂) and storing it in **SOIL, VEGETATION, and ECOSYSTEMS**, thereby reducing global warming.



ROLE OF SHEEP REARING IN CARBON SEQUESTRATION

1 Grassland-Based Carbon Storage



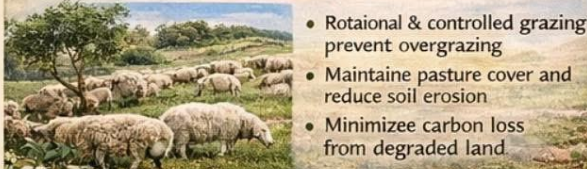
- Managed grazing promotes continuous grass growth.
- Deep root systems store carbon in soil.
- Permanent pastures act as long-term carbon sinks

2 Soil Organic Carbon Enhancement



- Sheep manure adds organic matter to soil.
- Improves soil structure and microbial activity.
- Increases soil carbon holding capacity.

3 Sustainable Grazing Systems



- Rotational & controlled grazing prevent overgrazing
- Maintain pasture cover and reduce soil erosion
- Minimize carbon loss from degraded land

4 Silvopastoral Systems



- Integration of sheep + trees + pasture
- Trees capture atmospheric CO₂
- Enhanced biodiversity and climate resilience.



ENVIRONMENTAL BENEFITS

- ✓ Reduced atmospheric CO₂
- ✓ Improved soil fertility and moisture retention
- ✓ Enhanced grassland biodiversity
- ✓ Prevention of land degradation & desertification



CONCLUSION

Traditional sheep rearing, when scientifically managed, is a **nature-based, low-cost** solution for climate change mitigation while ensuring **environmental sustainability** and rural livelihoods.

Well managed sheep rearing transforms grasslands into powerful carbon sinks."

FieldvetDrMSS

7. Carbon Sequestration through Sheep Rearing

Sustainable Livestock for Climate Change Mitigation

Sheep rearing, when managed under sustainable grazing systems, can contribute to carbon sequestration, helping reduce atmospheric carbon dioxide (CO₂). Proper pasture management with sheep improves soil organic carbon and ecosystem health.

What is Carbon Sequestration?

Carbon sequestration is the process of capturing and storing atmospheric carbon dioxide in soil, vegetation, and ecosystems, helping reduce greenhouse gas levels and mitigate climate change.

How Sheep Rearing Contributes to Carbon Sequestration

Improved Grassland Management

Sheep grazing stimulates grass regrowth and root development.

Impact

- Increased root biomass
- More carbon stored in soil
- Healthier pasture ecosystems

Soil Organic Matter Enrichment

Sheep manure and urine add organic nutrients to the soil.

Impact

- Improves soil fertility
- Enhances microbial activity
- Builds soil organic carbon

Regenerative Grazing Systems

Rotational or controlled grazing prevents overgrazing and land degradation.

Impact

- Promotes vegetation cover
- Enhances soil carbon storage
- Restores degraded lands

Utilization of Natural Vegetation

Sheep utilize native grasses, shrubs, and crop residues.

Impact

- Maintains natural ecosystems

- Reduces dependence on cultivated feed crops
- Supports sustainable land use

Improved Pasture Biodiversity

Moderate grazing helps maintain plant diversity in grasslands.

Impact

- Stronger ecosystem resilience
- Better carbon capture in vegetation and soil

Environmental Benefits

Sustainable sheep farming helps to:

- Improve soil health
- Reduce land degradation
- Support grassland ecosystems
- Increase carbon storage in soil

Role of Veterinarians and Farmers

Veterinarians and livestock managers can promote:

- Rotational grazing systems
- Healthy flock management
- Balanced stocking density
- Protection of grazing lands

These practices enhance sustainable livestock production and environmental conservation.

Significance for the Nation

Carbon-friendly sheep farming contributes to:

- Climate change mitigation
- Sustainable agriculture
- Rural livelihoods
- Ecosystem conservation

Key Message

“Sustainable sheep grazing not only produces food and income but also helps capture carbon and protect the planet.”

Global Sheep Industry: Future Growth Overview



FieldvetDrMSS

Meta AI

Section 2: Global & Industry Perspectives

8. Global Sheep Industry - Future Growth Overview

Growing Demand for Sheep Meat:

The global sheep meat market (lamb & mutton) is projected to expand steadily, with a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) around ~2.7% through 2030 driven by rising consumption of high-quality, protein-rich meats worldwide.

Global sheep meat production is expected to increase by about 15% by 2034, reaching around 19 million tonnes carcass-weight equivalent, fuelled by higher lambing rates and favourable prices.

Regional Consumption Trends:

Asia (especially China & India) is a major contributor to the future growth of sheep production and demand — China alone may account for around 17% of the additional production increase as diets evolve and meat consumption grows.

Middle East and Mediterranean regions are traditional strong markets for lamb and mutton and are expected to continue supporting demand.

Producer Confidence & Expansion:

Surveys from major sheep meat producing countries like Australia show strong producer confidence, with 52%+ of producers planning to increase flock size in 2026, indicating industry expansion momentum.

Value Chain & Investments:

Investments in technology, precision farming, and sustainable practices are rising (e.g., automated feeding, health data tracking), boosting productivity and operational efficiency.

Market expansion efforts and supply chain investments are underway to capitalize on both domestic and export opportunities, especially where demand is growing fastest.

Sheep Dairy & Specialty Products:

Beyond meat, the sheep milk market is one of the fastest growing segments, with an estimated CAGR ~6–7.5% through the late 2020s, as consumers seek alternative dairy products and premium cheeses.

Sustainability & Consumer Preferences:

Consumers increasingly prefer grass-fed, ethical and traceable meat products, creating niche premium segments within the industry.

Market Size Projections:

Some industry estimates forecast the mutton market to approach nearly USD 900 billion by 2035, reflecting long-term growth driven by global protein demand and trade expansion.

Key Drivers of Future Growth:

- ✓ Population Growth & Rising Incomes — more demand for protein-rich diets.
- ✓ Export Market Opportunities — especially from key producers such as Australia.
- ✓ Technology Adoption — improving productivity and reducing costs. ²
- ✓ Product Diversification — meat, milk, premium cheeses, organic wool segments.
- ✓ Sustainable Farming Practices — enhancing consumer appeal and environmental stewardship.

Challenges to Growth:**Wool Market Decline**

wool has lost value in many markets due to synthetic alternatives, prompting shifts toward meat-focused production.

Disease, Climate & Supply Risks

livestock disease outbreaks and climate variability remain ongoing challenges affecting flock sizes and productivity.

Policy & Trade Dynamics

regulations (e.g., export bans or changes) can impact trade flows and profitability.

Summary - Future Growth Outlook:

Overall, the sheep industry is expected to grow through the 2020s and into the 2030s due to:

- Rising meat demand, especially in Asia and the Middle East.
- Producer expansion and investment confidence.
- Growth in dairy and specialty product segments.
- Technological and sustainability-focused transformation.

This growth is steady, diversified, and supported by evolving consumer preferences, even as traditional components like wool face structural decline.

SHEEP FARMING: SWOT ANALYSIS

India & South Asia

INDIA

FieldvetDrMSS



Strengths

- Large indigenous sheep population
- Adapted to arid & dryland regions
- Low capital, simple housing
- Utilizes crop residues & wastelands
- High demand for mutton
- Livelihood for small farmers



Opportunities

- Urban demand for mutton
- Livestock Mission support
- Breed improvement programs
- Organic & export markets
- Middle East exports



Weaknesses

- Low productivity per animal
- High lamb mortality
- Poor breeding programs
- Shrinking grazing lands
- Inadequate veterinary services
- Unorganized markets



Threats

- Disease outbreaks (PPR, ET)
- Climate change & droughts
- Grazing land encroachment
- Predation & theft
- Policy neglect



SOUTH ASIA

(India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka)



Strengths

- Traditional sheep rearing
- Hardy local breeds
- Low-cost production
- Cultural meat demand
- Crop residues as feed



Opportunities

- Growing urban meat markets
- Regional disease control
- SAARC trade potential
- Women & youth in farming
- Climate-smart livestock



Weaknesses

- Low genetic potential
- Weak veterinary services
- High disease burden
- Lack of credit access
- Minimal processing



Threats

- Climate extremes & floods
- Transboundary diseases
- Feed & land competition
- Informal markets
- Political instability



FieldvetDrMSS



Sheep farming in India & South Asia is a low-input, climate-resilient livelihood system.

Productivity gains depend on better breeding, disease control, grazing management, and organized markets™



9. Sheep Farming: Swot Analysis - India & South Asia

India:

Strengths

- Large sheep population with hardy indigenous breeds
- Well adapted to arid, semi-arid & dryland regions
- Low capital investment & simple housing
- Efficient utilization of crop residues & wastelands
- High demand for mutton with premium prices
- Important livelihood for pastoralists & marginal farmers

Weaknesses

- Low productivity per animal
- High lamb mortality
- Poor organized breeding & limited AI coverage
- Shrinking grazing lands
- Inadequate veterinary outreach in migratory systems
- Unorganized marketing & price fluctuations

Opportunities

- Rising urban demand for sheep meat
- National Livestock Mission support
- Breed improvement & conservation programs
- Organic and branded mutton markets
- Export potential to Middle East countries
- Climate-resilient alternative to dairy farming

Threats

- Disease outbreaks (PPR, sheep pox, ET)
- Climate change & drought-induced feed scarcity
- Grazing land encroachment
- Predation & theft in open systems
- Policy bias toward dairy sector

South Asia

(India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka)

Strengths

- Long tradition of sheep rearing
- Hardy local breeds adapted to stress conditions
- Low-cost extensive production systems

- Strong cultural & religious meat demand
- Availability of crop residues as feed

Weaknesses

- Poor genetic potential & slow growth
- Weak veterinary & extension infrastructure
- High parasitic & disease burden
- Limited access to credit, insurance & markets
- Minimal value addition & processing facilities

Opportunities

- Expanding urban meat markets
- Regional disease control (PPR eradication)
- SAARC & Middle East trade opportunities
- Women & youth entrepreneurship
- Climate-smart livestock integration

Threats

- Climate extremes (droughts, floods)
- Transboundary animal diseases
- Feed & land competition
- Informal and exploitative market chains
- Political & trade instability

Key Message

□ Sheep farming in India and South Asia is a low-input, climate-resilient livelihood system. Productivity gains depend on better breeding, disease control, grazing management, and organized markets.

Unique Sheep Farms — of the World —

FieldvetDrMSS

Sheep farming systems across the world vary based on **climate, geography, breed specialization,** and **production goals.** Below are some of the most unique and remarkable **sheep farming**



1 New Zealand — Large-Scale Pasture-Based Sheep Farming

- ✓ One of the world's largest sheep populations
- ✓ Extensive grazing on natural grasslands
- ✓ Major exporter of lamb and wool
- ✓ Strong genetic improvement and traceability systems

Special Feature: Low-cost, high-efficiency pasture system

2 Australia —

Merino Wool Dominance

- ✓ Home of premium Merino sheep
- ✓ Fine wool production for global textile
- ✓ Advanced shearing and wool grading technology
- ✓ Strong biosecurity and breeding programs

Focus: Quality wool genetics and export economy

3 Iceland —

Free-Range Mountain Sheep System

- ✓ Sheep graze freely in highlands during summer.
- ✓ Round-up tradition called Réttir
- ✓ Highly hardy and cold-resistant breeds

Unique Aspect: Seasonal transhumance in extreme climates

4 Faroe Islands — Cliff-Grazing Sheep

- ✓ Sheep graze on steep coastal cliffs
- ✓ Adapted to harsh, windy maritime conditions
- ✓ Unique traditional management practices

Distinctive Feature: Extreme terrain adaptation

5 Netherlands —

Dairy Sheep Farming

- ✓ Specialized dairy sheep farms
- ✓ Production of sheep milk cheese and yogur.
- ✓ High-tech indoor housing and feeding systems

Market Orientation: Value-added dairy products

6 India —

Nomadic & Semi-Nomadic Systems

- ✓ Pastoral communities migrate seasonally.
- ✓ Indigenous breeds adapted to arid & semi-arid zones
- ✓ Low input, climate-resilient systems

Example: Traditional transhumance in Rajasthan & Tamil Nadu

7 United Kingdom —

Hill & Moorland Sheep Farming

- ✓ Sheep raised on upland pastures
- ✓ Breeds adapted to cold and wet climates
- ✓ Important for landscape conservation

Integrated Role: Agriculture & environmental stewardship



Key Learning for Veterinary & Animal Science Students

- ✓ Climate adaptation determines breed selection • Production goals (meat, milk, wool) shape Management
- ✓ Biosecurity and genetics drive profitability. ✓ Traditional systems can be highly sustainable.
- ✓ Traditional systems can be highly sustainable • Market orientation influences farm structure.

10. Unique Sheep Farms of the World

Sheep farming systems across the world vary based on climate, geography, breed specialization, and production goals. Below are some of the most unique and remarkable sheep farming models globally.

🇳🇿 New Zealand – Large-Scale Pasture-Based Sheep Farming:

- One of the world's largest sheep populations.
- Extensive grazing on natural grasslands.
- Major exporter of lamb and wool.
- Strong genetic improvement and traceability systems.

Special Feature: Low-cost, high-efficiency pasture system.

🇮🇸 Iceland – Free-Range Mountain Sheep System:

- Sheep graze freely in highlands during summer.
- Round-up tradition called Réttir.
- Highly hardy and cold-resistant breeds.
- Minimal input, natural production system.

Unique Aspect: Seasonal transhumance in extreme climates.

🇦🇺 Australia – Merino Wool Dominance:

- Home of premium Merino sheep.
- Fine wool production for global textile industry.
- Advanced shearing and wool grading technology.
- Strong biosecurity and breeding programs.

Focus: Quality wool genetics and export economy.

🇫🇷 Faroe Islands – Cliff-Grazing Sheep:

- Sheep graze on steep coastal cliffs.
- Adapted to harsh, windy maritime conditions.
- Unique traditional management practices.

Distinctive Feature: Extreme terrain adaptation.

🇳🇱 Netherlands – Dairy Sheep Farming:

- Specialized dairy sheep farms.
- Production of sheep milk cheese and yogurt.

- High-tech indoor housing and feeding systems.

Market Orientation: Value-added dairy products.

🇮🇳 India – Nomadic & Semi-Nomadic Systems:

- Pastoral communities migrate seasonally.
- Indigenous breeds adapted to arid and semi-arid zones.
- Low input, climate-resilient systems.

Example: Traditional transhumance in Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu.

🇬🇧 United Kingdom – Hill & Moorland Sheep Farming:

- Sheep raised on upland pastures.
- Breeds adapted to cold and wet climates.
- Important for landscape conservation.

Integrated Role: Agriculture + environmental stewardship.

🌐 Key Learning for Veterinary & Animal Science Students:

- Climate adaptation determines breed selection.
- Production goals (meat, milk, wool) shape management.
- Biosecurity and genetics drive profitability.
- Traditional systems can be highly sustainable.
- Market orientation influences farm structure.



Sheep Disease-Free Countries (WOAH-Based)



Nations free from major transboundary sheep diseases

FieldvetDrMSS



Foot-and-Mouth Disease (FMD) Free

Without Vaccination

- Australia
- New Zealand
- Ireland
- Iceland
- New Zealand
- United States
- Japan
- Norway
- United Kingdom
- Canada
- Chile
- Argentina
- Ireland
- Iceland
- Japan
- Uruguay



Peste des Petits Ruminants (PPR) Free • All EU Countries

- Australia
- New Zealand
- Canada
- New Zealand
- United States
- Japan
- United States
- Canada
- Chile
- Argentina
- United States
- Japan
- Chile
- Argentina



Sheep Pox & Goat Pox Free

- Australia
- New Zealand
- Iceland
- New Zealand
- European Union
- USA
- Canada
- Japan



Scrapie Free (Classical Form)

- Australia
- New Zealand
- New Zealand
- Japan
- Iceland



High Sheep Health Status

- Strict Biosecurity & Surveillance

- Australia
- Ireland
- Japan
- New Zealand
- Norway
- Sweden
- United Kingdom
- Sweden
- Finland

- Status Can Change Due to Outbreaks & Imports
- India, Africa & Most of Asia Are **NOT** PPR-Free
- No Country Is 100% Disease-Free



Note: "Disease-Free" means free from listed transboundary diseases under WOAH, not 100% disease-free.

FieldvetDrMSS

11. Sheep Disease-Free Countries (WOAH-based)

When people say “sheep disease-free countries”, they usually mean countries that are officially free (or largely free) from major transboundary sheep diseases as recognized by the WOAH (formerly OIE)—not that no sheep diseases exist at all.

Below is a practical and policy-oriented list, grouped by key diseases 

Countries free from Foot-and-Mouth Disease (FMD) (without vaccination)

These are often considered the gold standard for small ruminant health:

Australia, New Zealand, United Kingdom, Ireland, Iceland, Japan, Norway, Sweden, Finland, Switzerland, United States and Canada.

Countries free from Peste des Petits Ruminants (PPR)

PPR is the most important sheep/goat disease globally.

Australia, New Zealand, All European Union countries, United States, Canada, Japan, Chile, Argentina and Uruguay.

 India, Africa, and most of Asia are not PPR-free.

Countries free from Sheep Pox & Goat Pox

Australia, New Zealand, EU countries, USA, Canada and Japan.

Countries free from Scrapie (classical form):

Scrapie freedom is rare and tightly regulated.

Australia, New Zealand, Iceland and Japan

(Some EU countries have controlled or negligible risk rather than absolute freedom.)

Countries often described as “high sheep health status”:

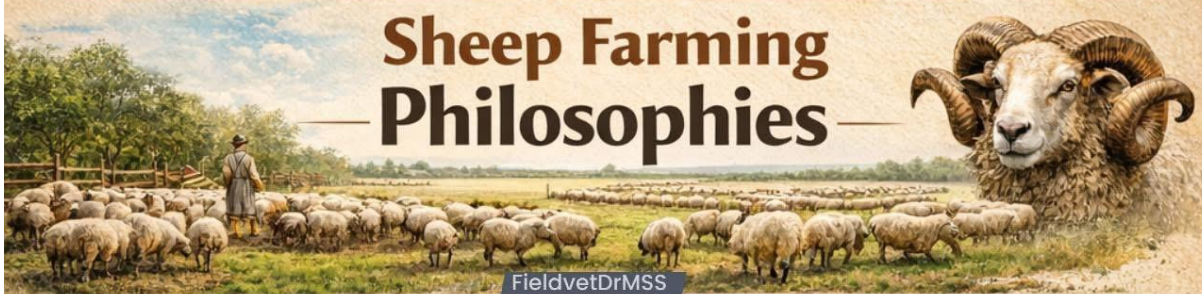
(Strict biosecurity, quarantine, and surveillance)

Australia, New Zealand, United Kingdom, Ireland, Norway, Sweden, Finland and Japan.

Important clarification:

-  No country is 100% disease-free
-  The term usually means free from listed transboundary diseases under WOAH
- Status can change due to outbreaks, imports, or wildlife reservoirs.

Sheep Farming Philosophies



FieldvetDrMSS

Sheep farming philosophies reflect the approach, management style, and long-term vision adopted by farmers to ensure **profitability**, **sustainability**, and **animal welfare**.

1 Traditional / Extensive System Philosophy

-  Based on natural grazing systems
-  Low input – low investment model
-  Indigenous breeds adapted to local climate

Best suited for: Dryland and pastoral regions.



2 Commercial / Intensive System Philosophy

-  Scientific feeding and housing
-  Focus on maximum meat, wool, or milk production
-  Breed improvement and planned breeding

Goal: High productivity and faster turnover.



3 Sustainable & Eco-Friendly Philosophy

-  Integrates sheep with crop farming
-  Uses manure for soil fertility
-  Emphasizes pasture management, rotational grazing
-  Reduces chemical input

Focus: Long term environmental balance.



4 Genetic Improvement Philosophy

-  Selection of superior rams
-  Avoidance of inbreeding
-  Performance recording and culling
-  Use of AI (where feasible)



5 Welfare-Oriented Philosophy

-  Adequate housing and ventilation
-  Proper nutrition and clean water
-  Stress reduction during handling
-  Humane disease control and treatment



6 Value-Addition & Market-Oriented Philosophy

-  Target festive and export markets
-  Breed selection based on market demand.
-  Direct marketing and branding
-  Processing (meat cuts, wool products)



7 Risk Management Philosophy

-  Vaccination and biosecurity
-  Insurance and diversification
-  Climate adaptation strategies
-  Record keeping for decision-making



Key Principle: Successful sheep farming balances productivity, sustainability, welfare, and profitability



#FieldVet

www.fieldvet.in

FieldvetDrMSS/Sheep Farming Philosophies



Section 3: Basics & Terminologies

12. Sheep Farming Philosophies

Sheep farming philosophies reflect the approach, management style, and long-term vision adopted by farmers to ensure profitability, sustainability, and animal welfare.

1 Traditional / Extensive System Philosophy

- Based on natural grazing systems.
- Low input – low investment model.
- Indigenous breeds adapted to local climate.
- Focus on survival, hardiness, and flock size.

Best suited for: Dryland and pastoral regions.

2 Commercial / Intensive System Philosophy

- Scientific feeding and housing.
- Focus on maximum meat, wool, or milk production.
- Breed improvement and planned breeding.
- Use of veterinary health programs and vaccination schedules.

Goal: High productivity and faster turnover.

3 Sustainable & Eco-Friendly Philosophy

- Integrates sheep with crop farming.
- Uses manure for soil fertility.
- Emphasizes pasture management and rotational grazing.
- Reduces chemical input.

Focus: Long-term environmental balance.

4 Genetic Improvement Philosophy

- Selection of superior rams.
- Avoidance of inbreeding.
- Performance recording and culling.
- Use of AI (where feasible).

Objective: Improve growth rate, fertility, disease resistance.

5 Welfare-Oriented Philosophy

- Adequate housing and ventilation.
- Proper nutrition and clean water.
- Stress reduction during handling.
- Humane disease control and treatment.

Principle: Productivity follows welfare.

6 Value-Addition & Market-Oriented Philosophy

- Target festive and export markets.
- Breed selection based on market demand.
- Direct marketing and branding.
- Processing (meat cuts, wool products).

7 Risk Management Philosophy

- Vaccination and biosecurity.
- Insurance and diversification.
- Climate adaptation strategies.
- Record keeping for decision-making.

Key Principle:

Successful sheep farming balances productivity, sustainability, welfare, and profitability.

COMMON TERMINOLOGIES USED IN SHEEP PRODUCTION

FieldvetDrMSS



1. Sheep Classification

- **Ram** – Adult male sheep
- **Ewe** – Adult female sheep
- **Lamb** – Sheep up to 12 months
- **Hogget** – Sheep 12-24 months
- **Wether** – Castrated male sheep



2. Reproductive Terminology

- **Estrus (Heat)** – Ewe in heat
- **Gestation Period** ~ 150 days
- **Lambing** – Giving birth
- **Twinning Rate** – Twin births



3. Feeding & Nutrition

- **Roughage** – Pasture, hay
- **Concentrate** – Energy feed
- **Creep Feeding** – Lamb supplements
- **Body Condition Score (BCS)**



4. Flock & Farm Management

- **Stocking Density** – Sheep per area
- **Weaning** – Lamb separation
- **Culling** – Removal of poor stock
- **Shearing** – Wool removal



5. Health & Disease Terms

- **Endemic Disease** – Common locally
- **Zoonotic Disease** – To humans
- **Deworming** – Worm control
- **Quarantine** – Isolation of sheep



7. Wool & Fiber Terminology

- **Fleece** – Shorn wool
- **Micron** – Fiber diameter
- **Staple Length** – Wool fiber length
- **Crimp** – Wool waviness



8. Marketing & Economics

- **Live Weight** – Weight before sale
- **Dressing %** – Carcass yield
- **Market Age** – Age at selling
- **Value Addition** – Product enhancement



Educational Use



Veterinary & Animal Science Students



Sheep Farmers & Extension Workers



Competitive Exams: ICAR, PSC, UPSC-ARS

#Fieldvet | Veterinary Extension Education

13. Common Terminologies Used in Sheep Production

1. Sheep Classification:

- Ram – Adult male sheep (breeding male)
- Ewe – Adult female sheep
- Lamb – Sheep up to 12 months of age
- Hogget – Sheep between 12–24 months
- Weather – Castrated male sheep

2. Reproductive Terminology:

- Estrus (Heat) – Period when ewe accepts ram
- Estrous Cycle – Interval between heats (~17 days)
- Breeding Season – Period of natural sexual activity
- Flushing – Extra feeding before breeding to increase ovulation
- Gestation Period – Pregnancy duration (~150 days)
- Lambing – Act of parturition in sheep
- Lambing Percentage – Lambs born per 100 ewes
- Twinning Rate – Proportion of twin births

3. Feeding & Nutrition:

- Roughage – High-fiber feed (pasture, hay, straw)
- Concentrate – Energy/protein-rich feed
- Maintenance Ration – Feed to maintain body weight
- Creep Feeding – Supplemental feed for lambs
- Body Condition Score (BCS) – Fat reserves assessment (1–5 scale)

4. Flock & Farm Management:

- Flock – Group of sheep managed together
- Stocking Density – Number of sheep per unit area
- Grazing System – Method of pasture use
- Weaning – Separation of lamb from ewe
- Culling – Removal of unproductive animals
- Docking – Tail removal in lambs
- Shearing – Removal of wool

5. Health & Disease Terms:

- Endemic Disease – Constantly present in an area
- Zoonotic Disease – Transmissible to humans
- Deworming – Anthelmintic treatment
- FAMACHA Score – Eye color score for anemia
- Quarantine – Isolation of new/sick animals

- Biosecurity – Disease prevention measures

6. Production & Performance:

- Growth Rate – Weight gain per unit time
- Feed Conversion Ratio (FCR) – Feed per kg gain
- Mortality Rate – Percentage of deaths
- Replacement Rate – New breeding stock added annually
- Lamb Crop – Total lambs produced in a season

7. Wool & Fiber Terminology:

- Fleece – Wool coat removed at shearing
- Staple Length – Length of wool fibers
- Crimp – Natural waviness of wool
- Micron – Fiber diameter measurement
- Skirting – Removal of inferior wool

8. Marketing & Economics:

- Live Weight – Weight before slaughter
- Dressing Percentage – Carcass % of live weight
- Market Age – Age at sale
- Value Addition – Processing to enhance income

Educational Use:

- ✓ Veterinary & Animal Science Students
- ✓ Sheep Farmers & Extension Workers

Competitive Exams (ICAR, PSC, UPSC-ARS)

ESSENTIALS OF COMMERCIAL SHEEP FARMING.

A COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE FOR NEW FARMERS (INDIA FOCUS)

1. BREED SELECTION

MEAT (MUTTON): MECHERI, NELLORE, MADRAS RED (SOUTH), DECCANI (WEST).



WOOL & MEAT: MARWARI, RAMPUR BUSHAIR (NORTH).



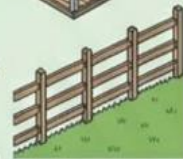
SELECT REGIONAL ADAPTED BREEDS.

2. HOUSING & INFRASTRUCTURE

FLOOR SPACE: 12-15 SQ. FT. PER ADULT (COVERED).

ELEVATED FLOORING: SLOTTED WOOD/PLASTIC FOR MANURE & DRYNESS.

FENCING: SECURE PERIMETER (4-5 FT HIGH).



3. FEEDING & NUTRITION



STALL-FEEDING (INTENSIVE) MIX:

GREEN FODDER: LUCERNE, BERSEEM, CO-4.

DRY FODDER: SORGHUM STOVER, MAIZE STRAW.

CONCENTRATE FEED: MAIZE, OIL CAKES, BRAN (200-500g/day).



PROVIDE MINERAL LICKS.

4. HEALTH & PREVENTIVE CARE



DEWORMING: 3-4 TIMES A YEAR (PRE/POST MONSOON).



VACCINATION SCHEDULE:

ET (Enterotoxaemia): PRE-MONSOON.

PPR (Peste des Petits Ruminants): EVERY 3 YEARS.

FMD (Foot and Mouth Disease): TWICE A YEAR.

SHEEP POX: ANNUAL.



5. ECONOMIC MANAGEMENT



FLOCK RATIO: 1 RAM PER 20-25 EWES.

LAMBING INTERVAL: AIM FOR 3 LAMBINGS EVERY 2 YEARS (CONTROLLED BREEDING).



CULLING: REMOVE OLDER RAMS & UNPRODUCTIVE EWES.

FAST TURNOVER & MULTI-INCOME (MEAT, WOOL, MANURE, MILK).

SHEEP FARMING FOR PROFIT

SHEEP FARMING FOR GROWTH

FieldvetDrMSS

14. Basics of Commercial Sheep Farming: (India Focus)

Commercial sheep farming in India is a highly profitable venture, particularly in semi-arid and hilly regions, due to the low investment required and the steady demand for mutton and wool.

Successful sheep farming relies on a "Three-Pillar" approach: Breed Selection, Nutrition, and Health Management.

1. Selecting the Right Breed:

The choice of breed depends on your primary goal: meat (mutton) or wool. In India, regional breeds often perform best due to their natural immunity.

Region, Popular Breeds & Purpose:

South India

- Mecheri, Nellore, Madras Red
- High-quality Mutton

North India

- Marwari, Gaddi, Rampur Bushair
- Wool & Meat

West India

- Deccani, Patanwadi
- Dual Purpose

2. Housing and Infrastructure:

Sheep require clean, dry, and well-ventilated housing.

- **Floor Space:** An adult sheep needs approximately 12 to 15 sq. ft. of covered space.
- **Elevated Flooring:** Slotted wooden or plastic floors are increasingly popular as they keep the sheep dry and make manure collection easier.
- **Fencing:** A secure perimeter (usually 4–5 feet high) is essential to protect the flock from predators.

3. Feeding and Nutrition:

Nutrition is the largest overhead in commercial farming.

- **Grazing (Extensive):** Traditional method where sheep graze for 6–8 hours daily.
- **Stall-Feeding (Intensive):** Ideal for meat production. Includes a mix of:
 - **Green Fodder:** Legumes (Lucerne, Berseem) and grasses (CO-4, Guinea grass).
 - **Dry Fodder:** Sorghum stover or maize straw.

- **Concentrate Feed:** A mix of maize, oil cakes, and bran (usually 200g–500g per day depending on age/pregnancy).
- **Mineral Licks:** Essential for preventing metabolic diseases.

4. Health & Preventive Care:

Sheep are susceptible to internal parasites and specific viral outbreaks.

Deworming:

Must be done at least 3–4 times a year, ideally before and after the monsoon.

Vaccination Schedule:

- ET (Enterotoxaemia): Pre-monsoon.
- PPR (Peste des Petits Ruminants): Once every 3 years.
- FMD (Foot and Mouth Disease): Twice a year.
- Sheep Pox: Annual vaccination.

5. Economic Management:

- **Flock Ratio:** Maintain 1 Ram (male) for every 20–25 Ewes (females) for optimum breeding.
- **Lambing Interval:** Aim for 3 lambings every 2 years through controlled breeding.
- **Culling:** Remove unproductive ewes and older rams every year to maintain flock vigor.

Key Advantages for New Farmers:

- **Fast Turnover:** Lambs reach marketable age (25–30 kg) within 6 to 9 months.
- **Multi-Income:** Revenue from meat, wool, manure, and milk.

High Prolificacy: Many breeds have a high twinning rate.

SHEEP FARMING

Field Awareness and Veterinary Management Guide

By #Fieldvet Dr. M. S. Saravanan, B.V.Sc., M.A., PGDCM

Introduction

Sheep farming is vital for millions of small-holder farmers in semi-arid and arid regions of India. Key challenges include diseases, parasites, grazing issues, and antimicrobial resistance. Veterinary care and farmer awareness are essential for healthy and productive flocks.

Aim & Purpose

To improve field-level veterinary management and awareness.

- Promote disease prevention, flock health, vaccination, and sustainable grazing practices.

Key Message

**Healthy Flocks → Healthy Farmers →
→ Sustainable Livestock Future**

Sharing knowledge ensures healthy, productive, and sustainable sheep farming.

Aim & Purpose

To improve field-level veterinary management and awareness.

- Promote disease prevention, flock health, vaccination, and sustainable grazing practices.

Stakeholder Collaboration

- Sheep farmers and shepherds
- Field veterinarians and para-vets
- Veterinary universities and researchers
- Government livestock departments
- NGOs and livestock extension workers

#Fieldvet Dr. M. S. Saravanan,
B.V.Sc., M.A., PGDCM



15. Sheep Farming - Field Awareness and Veterinary Management Guide

Sheep farming plays an important role in rural livestock systems, especially in semi-arid and arid regions. In India, millions of smallholder farmers and pastoral communities depend on sheep for their livelihood.

Sheep provide:

- Meat (Mutton) – High-value protein
- Wool – Raw material for textiles
- Manure – Organic fertilizer for crops
- Income – Quick financial support for rural families

However, sheep farming faces challenges such as diseases, parasite infestations, poor grazing management, and antimicrobial resistance. Proper veterinary care and farmer awareness are essential for healthy and productive flocks.

Aim

To improve field-level awareness and veterinary management practices in sheep farming through practical and science-based knowledge.

Purpose

This guide helps to:

- Promote scientific sheep farming
- Improve disease prevention and flock health
- Strengthen vaccination and parasite control
- Create awareness about antimicrobial & anthelmintic resistance
- Encourage sustainable grazing management
- Support field veterinarians and extension workers

Stakeholder Collaboration

Successful sheep farming requires cooperation among:

- Sheep farmers and shepherds
- Field veterinarians and para-vets
- Veterinary universities and researchers
- Government livestock departments
- Livestock extension agencies and NGOs

Knowledge sharing improves animal health, productivity, and rural livelihoods.

Key Message

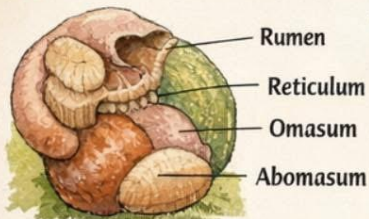
Healthy Flocks → Healthy Farmers → Sustainable Livestock Future

SPECIAL ORGANS OF SHEEP AND THEIR PURPOSE

Key Anatomical Adaptations in Sheep (*Ovis aries*)

FieldvetDrMSS

1 Ruminant Stomach



► Efficient Digestion of Plant Material



2 Dental Pad

► Tough Pad Instead of Upper Incisors

2 Dental Pad



► Tough Pad Instead of Upper Incisors

3 Cloven Hooves



► Stability on Rough Terrain



4 Wool Follicles

► Thermal Insulation

4 Wool Follicles



5 Horns (in some breeds)

► Defense & Mating Role

6 Preorbital Glands



► Scent Marking

7 Interdigital Glands



► Trail Marking

8 Inguinal & Supramammary Glands



► Maternal Bonding

9 Large Field of Vision



► Wide Panoramic Vision (270–320°)

10 Vomeronasal Organ



► Detects Pheromones

11 Spiral Colon



► Water Reabsorption

★ Summary ★

- ✓ Efficient Grazing & Digestion
- ✓ Scent Communication
- ✓ Predator Detection
- ✓ Thermoregulation via Wool
- ✓ Reproductive Adaptation

FieldvetDrMSS

Section 4: Sheep Biology & Behaviour

16. Special Organs of Sheep and Their Purpose

Sheep possess several specialized anatomical structures that help them adapt to grazing life, predator avoidance, thermoregulation, reproduction, and social behaviour.

1 Ruminant Stomach (Four-Compartment Stomach)

Sheep are ruminants with a specialized digestive system consisting of:

▪ Rumen

- Largest compartment
- Fermentation vat containing microbes
- Breaks down cellulose from grasses
- Produces volatile fatty acids (energy source)

▪ Reticulum

- Honeycomb structure
- Traps foreign materials
- Initiates cud regurgitation

▪ Omasum

- “Manyplies”
- Absorbs water and minerals
- Reduces particle size

▪ Abomasum

- True glandular stomach
- Secretes HCl and digestive enzymes
- Similar to monogastric stomach

Purpose: Efficient digestion of fibrous pasture and conversion of plant material into energy and protein.

2 Dental Pad (Instead of Upper Incisors)

- Sheep lack upper incisors
- Have a tough dental pad on upper jaw
- Lower incisors press against pad during grazing

Purpose: Efficient clipping of grass close to the ground.

3 Cloven Hooves

- Two digits per foot
- Hard keratinized structure

- Flexible for uneven terrain

Purpose:

- Shock absorption
- Stability in rocky or hilly grazing lands
- Improved mobility

4 Wool Follicles

- Primary and secondary follicles
- Produce fleece (wool fibers)

Purpose:

- Thermal insulation
- Protection from rain and UV radiation
- Economic importance (wool production)

5 Horns (in some breeds)

- Present in rams, sometimes ewes
- Made of keratin covering a bony core

Purpose:

- Defense against predators
- Dominance and mating competition
- Breed identification

6 Preorbital (Infraorbital) Glands

- Located below the eyes
- Secrete waxy substance

Purpose:

- Scent marking
- Social communication
- Territorial behavior

7 Interdigital Glands

- Located between the hooves
- Produce scent secretion

Purpose:

- Trail marking
- Flock identification
- Social communication

8 Inguinal and Supramammary Glands

- Located near udder region

Purpose:

- Lamb recognition
- Maternal bonding
- Individual scent identification

9 Large Field of Vision (Eye Placement)

- Eyes placed laterally
- Wide panoramic vision (~270–320°)

Purpose:

- Predator detection
- Flock coordination
- Survival advantage

10 Vomeronasal Organ (Jacobson's Organ)

- Located in nasal cavity

Purpose:

- Detects pheromones
- Reproductive behavior regulation
- Ram response to estrus (Flehmen reaction)

11 Spiral Colon

- Highly coiled large intestine

Purpose:

- Efficient water reabsorption
- Compact fecal pellet formation
- Adaptation to dry environments

Summary

Sheep possess specialized organs that support:

- ✓ Efficient grazing and digestion
- ✓ Social communication through scent glands
- ✓ Predator avoidance
- ✓ Thermoregulation via wool

Reproductive efficiency



SLEEPING PATTERNS IN SHEEP

Sleep Behaviour, Physiology & Disorders

FieldvetDrMSS

Daily Sleep Duration



- Sheep sleep **3-5 hours/day**
- Mostly during **Night**
- **Early morning**

✓ Sheep are prey animals — constant alertness is essential

Types of Sleep in Sheep

1 Non-REM Sleep

- Majority of sleep time
- Occurs while.
 - **Standing**
 - **Lying down**
- Light sleep quick arousal



✓ REM sleep deprivation affects behaviour and productivity



2 REM Sleep (Deep Sleep)

- Very short duration
- Occurs **only** when lying down
- Characterized by:
 - **Muscle relaxation**
 - **Occasional twitching**

✓ Essential for brain function behaviour and productivity



✓ Standing sleep

Common during Non-REM Sleep
Allows rapid escape.

Sleeping Postures

1 Standing sleep

- Common during **Non-REM sleep**.
- Allows rapid escape
- **Lying sleep**
- Required for **REM sleep**:



✓ Comfort and security influence lying behaviour.

Circadian Rhythm

- Sheep are **diurnal**:
- More alert during daylight
- Sleep mainly at night
- Influenced by:
 - **Light, Feeding time**
 - **Environmental safety**



Circadian Rhythm

- Sleep mainly at night
- **Feeding time** influenced by light
- **Feeding time**

Effect of Predation & Stress

1 Sleep Deprivation

- Overcrowding
- Transport stress
- Poor housing
- Predation pressure



✓ Chronic stress severely disrupts sleep.

Management Practices for Healthy Sleep



- ✗ Adequate space
- ✗ Transport stress
- ✗ Poor housing
- ✗ Predation pressure



- ✓ Excessive lying
- Weakness
- Metabolic disorders
- **Reluctance to lie**

- Reluctance to lie
- Pain
- Fear
- Hard/slippery floors



KEY TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ✓ Adequate space
- ✓ Dry, comfortable bedding
- ✓ Low night-time disturbance
- ✓ Proper ventilation
- ✓ Predator control
- ✓ Pain and parasite control



#FieldVet | #SheepBehaviour | #AnimalWelfare | #VeterinaryEducation

FieldvetDrMSS

17. Sheep Vision and Behaviour

Eye Position & Field of Vision:

- Eyes are laterally placed
- Wide panoramic vision: ~300–320°
- Narrow binocular vision: 30–40°
- Enables early predator detection
 - ◆ Excellent peripheral vision
 - ◆ Poor depth judgment

Visual Acuity:

- Lower visual sharpness than humans
- Detects movement better than detail
- Difficulty recognizing stationary objects

Sudden movements cause more fear than still objects

Colour Vision:

- Dichromatic vision

Can see:

- Blue
- Green
- Cannot distinguish:
 - Red vs Green
 - Orange vs Yellow

Blue/green handling equipment is preferred

Depth Perception:

- Limited due to narrow binocular vision
- Shadows appear as holes or obstacles

Hesitation at:

- Shadows
- Drains
- Slatted or shiny floors

Avoid abrupt floor or colour changes

Low-Light & Night Vision:

- Presence of Tapetum lucidum

Good vision at:

- Dawn
- Dusk
- Low light
- Sudden bright light causes stress

Gradual lighting improves calm movement

Blind Spots:

- Directly behind the sheep
- Very close in front of the nose

Approach from the side to avoid panic

Motion Sensitivity - Highly sensitive to:

- Rapid movement
- Hand waving
- Calm, slow movements reduce fear response

Controlled dog movement is essential

Vision & Flocking Behaviour:

- Strong reliance on visual contact
- Prefer moving towards other sheep
- Isolation causes extreme stress

Use a lead sheep when moving flocks

Clinical & Welfare Importance:

Eye conditions affecting vision:

- Infectious keratoconjunctivitis
- Trauma
- Entropion (lambs)

Poor vision leads to: Reduced grazing, Weight loss, Higher predation risk

Key Take-Home Messages:

- ✓ Wide vision, poor depth perception
- ✓ Sensitive to shadows and movement
- ✓ Calm handling improves welfare
- ✓ Vision strongly influences flock behaviour

Different Types of Bleating

in Sheep and Their Significance

FieldvetDrMSS

Bleating is the primary vocal communication system in sheep. Variations in pitch, intensity, and frequency convey information related to **health, emotion, social bonding, and environmental stress**.



1. Maternal (Contact) Bleating

Characteristics:

- Low-pitched, soft, short calls
- Observed in:
 - Ewe calling her lamb
 - Lamb responding to the dam

Normal



2. Distress / Separation Bleating

Characteristics:

- Loud, high-pitched, continuous
- Observed in:
 - Separation from flock or dam
 - Transport and handling



3. Hunger or Feed-Seeking Bleating

Characteristics:

- Repetitive, demanding vocalization
- Feed deprivation,
- Delayed feeding



4. Pain-Associated Bleating

Characteristics:

- Sharp, sudden, intense bleats
- Lameness
- Mastitis
- Injury or dystocia



5. Pain-Associated Bleating

Characteristics:

- Sharp, sudden, intense bleats
- Lameness
- Mastitis
- Injury or dystocia



6. Sexual or Rut-Related Bleating (Rams)

Characteristics:

- Loud, repetitive vocalization
- Breeding season
- Presence of ewes



5. Stress-Related Bleating

Characteristics:

- Heat stress
- Overcrowding
- Poor ventilation



7. Lamb Distress Bleating

Characteristics:

- Hunger, Hypothermia, Diarrhea
- Early indicator of neonatal distress



8. Weak or Absent Bleating

Characteristics:

- Very low intensity or no vocalization
- Severe illness
- Exhaustion
- Dehydration



Veterinary and Management Importance

- ◆ Non-invasive indicator of health and welfare
- ◆ Aids in early disease detection
- ◆ Useful in flock monitoring and triage
- ◆ Reflects nutrition, housing, and handling quality

Any sudden change in normal bleating pattern should prompt immediate investigation.

FieldvetDrMSS

Field Tip:



18. Types of Bleating in Sheep and Their Significance

Bleating is the primary vocal communication of sheep. Different sounds convey specific behavioural, physiological, or emotional states within the flock. Understanding these vocalizations helps farmers detect stress, illness, hunger, or social interaction early.

1 Contact Bleat

Description: Soft, short bleating sound

Purpose:

- Communication between ewe and lamb
- Maintaining flock contact
- Mother–offspring recognition

Significance: Indicates normal social bonding and flock cohesion.

2 Distress Bleat

Description: Loud, repeated, high-pitched bleating

Causes:

- Separation from flock
- Predator threat
- Lamb separated from ewe

Significance: Signals fear, stress, or urgent need for help.

3 Hunger Bleat

Description: Persistent and rhythmic bleating

Common Situations:

- Lambs waiting to suckle
- Sheep expecting feed
- Delayed feeding schedule

Significance: Indicates feeding demand or nutritional need.

4 Pain Bleat

Description: Sharp, sudden cry

Possible Causes:

- Injury
- Disease
- Foot problems
- Difficult lambing

Significance: May signal health problems requiring immediate attention.

Mating Bleat

Description: Repeated bleating during courtship

Occurs During:

- Breeding season
- Ram approaching ewe in estrus

Significance: Associated with reproductive behaviour and mating activity.

Isolation Bleat

Description: Long and continuous calling

Occurs When:

- Sheep is lost or isolated
- Lamb separated from mother

Significance: Reflects social stress and flock separation.

Contentment Bleat

Description: Low, gentle murmuring sound

Occurs When:

- Sheep grazing peacefully
- Lamb suckling
- Comfortable environment

Significance: Indicates relaxed and satisfied animals.

Importance for Sheep Farmers

Understanding bleating patterns helps in:

- ✓ Early detection of disease or injury
- ✓ Monitoring feeding behaviour
- ✓ Identifying stress or predator threats
- ✓ Managing mother–lamb bonding
- ✓ Improving animal welfare

Veterinary Insight

Changes in vocalization patterns may indicate health issues, stress, nutritional deficiency, or environmental problems, making bleat recognition a useful management tool in sheep farming.

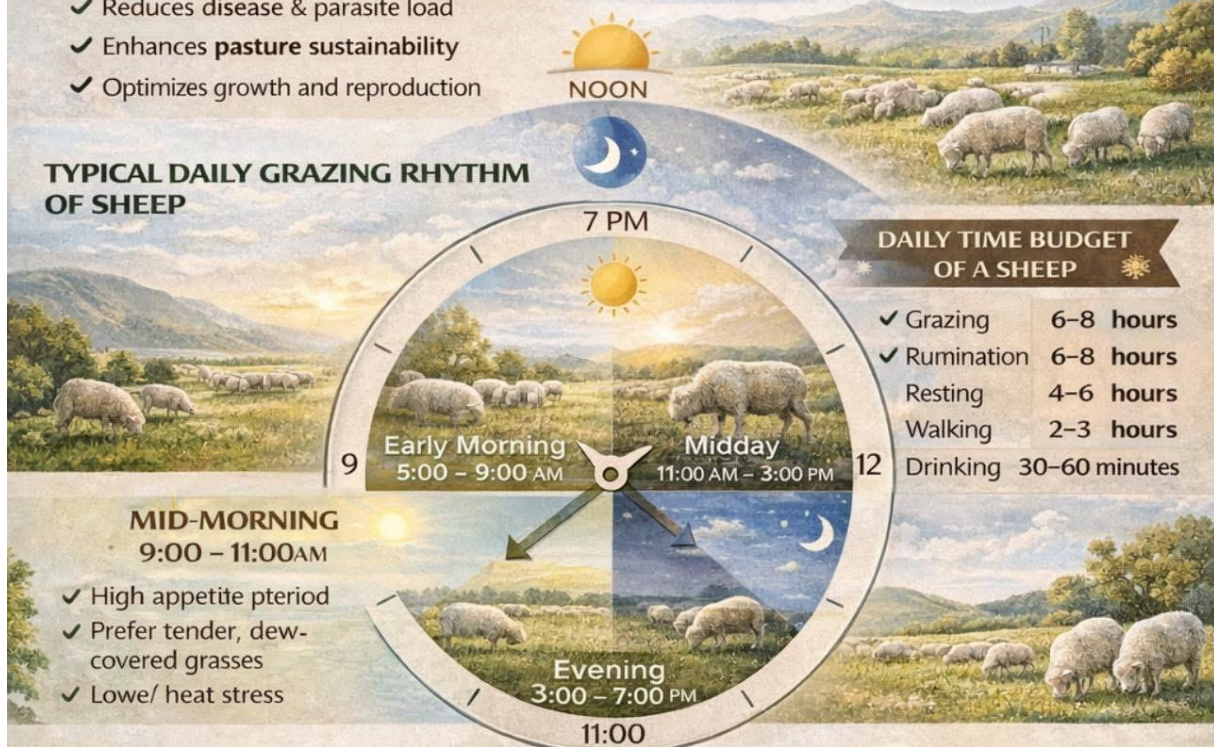
DAILY GRAZING PATTERNS OF SHEEP

WHY UNDERSTANDING GRAZING PATTERNS MATTERS

FieldvetDrMSS

- ✓ Improves feed efficiency
- ✓ Reduces disease & parasite load
- ✓ Enhances pasture sustainability
- ✓ Optimizes growth and reproduction

TYPICAL DAILY GRAZING RHYTHM OF SHEEP



GRAZING BEHAVIOUR CHARACTERISTICS

- ✓ Prefer **short**, dense grasses
- ✓ Highly selective feeders
- ✓ Graze against wind direction
- ✓ Move as a flock
- ✓ Avoid wet, muddy or contaminated areas

IMPACT OF POOR GRAZING MANAGEMENT

- ⚠ Reduced intake
- ⚠ Weight loss
- ⚠ Poor wool growth
- ⚠ Low fertility
- ⚠ Increased parasitism

FACTORS AFFECTING DAILY GRAZING PATTERN

- Temperature & humidity
- Pasture availability & quality
- Breed & physiological stage
- Water availability
- Parasite pressure
- Predation risk

GOOD GRAZING MANAGEMENT PRACTICES

- ✓ Allow early morning & evening grazing
- ✓ Avoid midday grazing in hot seasons
- ✓ Provide shade & clean water
- ✓ Use rotational grazing
- ✓ Avoid overgrazing

SEASONAL VARIATION IN GRAZING

"Right grazing time ensures healthy sheep and sustainable pastures."

"Observe the sheep – nature teaches the right grazing rhythm."

FieldvetDrMSS

*fieldvet

19. Daily Grazing Patterns of Sheep

Why Understanding Grazing Patterns Matters:

- Improves feed efficiency
- Reduces disease & parasite load
- Enhances pasture sustainability
- Optimizes growth and reproduction

Typical Daily Grazing Rhythm of Sheep:



Early Morning (5:00 – 9:00 AM)

- Peak grazing period
- High appetite after night fasting
- Prefer tender, dew-covered grasses
- Lower heat stress

✓ Best time for open grazing



Mid-Morning (9:00 – 11:00 AM):

- Moderate grazing
- Intermittent walking & rumination
- Selective feeding on preferred plants



Midday (11:00 AM – 3:00 PM):

- Minimal grazing
- Sheep rest, seek shade
- Main activity: rumination
- Increased water intake

⚠ Heat stress risk if no shade



Evening (3:00 – 7:00 PM):

- Second peak grazing period
- Good intake before night rest
- Prefer leafy grasses.

✓ Ideal time for controlled grazing



Night (7:00 PM – 5:00 AM):

- Resting & rumination
- Limited movement
- Body recovery & digestion

Daily Time Budget of a Sheep:

Activity & Average Duration

- Grazing: 6–8 hours
- Rumination: 6–8 hours
- Resting: 4–6 hours
- Walking: 2–3 hours
- Drinking: 30–60 minutes

Grazing Behaviour Characteristics:

- Prefer short, dense grasses
- Highly selective feeders
- Graze against wind direction
- Move as a flock
- Avoid wet, muddy, or contaminated areas

Factors Affecting Daily Grazing Pattern:

- Temperature & humidity
- Pasture availability & quality
- Breed & physiological stage
- Water availability
- Parasite pressure
- Predation risk

Impact Of Poor Grazing Management:

- ⚠ Reduced intake
- ⚠ Weight loss
- ⚠ Poor wool growth
- ⚠ Low fertility
- ⚠ Increased parasitism

Good Grazing Management Practices:

- ✓ Allow early morning & evening grazing
- ✓ Avoid midday grazing in hot seasons
- ✓ Provide shade & clean water
- ✓ Use rotational grazing
- ✓ Avoid overgrazing
- ✓ Adjust grazing time during extreme weather

Seasonal Variation in Grazing:

- Summer: Early morning & late evening grazing
- Winter: Extended midday grazing
- Rainy season: Careful grazing to avoid parasites

Key Message:

“Right grazing time ensures healthy sheep and sustainable pastures.”

“Observe the sheep—nature teaches the right grazing rhythm.”

TYPES OF COAT COLOUR IN SHEEP AND ITS SIGNIFICANCE



FieldvetDrMSS

WHAT IS COAT COLOUR?

Coat colour in sheep is determined by:

- Genetics (melanin type & distribution)
- Breed characteristics
- Environmental adaptation

It influences heat tolerance, management, disease resistance, and economic value:



COMMON TYPES OF COAT COLOUR IN SHEEP

1. WHITE (Most Common & Preferred)

- Pure white or creamy white fleece
- Pink skin underneath

✓ Significance

- ✓ Highly preferred for wool production
- ✓ Easy to dye into any colour
- ✓ Widely used in commercial sheep farming
- ✗ Prone to sunburn & photosensitization in extreme heat



2. BLACK

- Uniform black fleece
- Dark skin and hooves

✓ Significance

- ✓ Better resistance to sunburn
- ✓ Often hardy and disease-resistant
- ✗ Preferred for natural-colour wool markets
- ✗ Absorbs more heat; Less preferred in commercial wool grading



3. BROWN / RED / TAN

- Light brown to dark reddish shades
- Often uneven distribution

✓ Significance

- ✓ Strong rustic and hardy appearance
- ✓ Adapted to dry & semi-arid regions
- ✗ Preferred in meat-type indigenous breeds



4. GREY

- Mixture of black and white fibres
- Silver-grey to dark-grey shades

✓ Significance

- ✓ Indicates genetic diversity
- ✓ Moderate heat tolerance
- ✓ Accepted in niche wool markets



5. SPOTTED / PATCHED (PIEBALD)

- White base with black or brown patches
- Irregular pattern

✓ Significance

- ✓ Common in indigenous & non-descript sheep
- ✗ Lower wool uniformity



6. MIXED / VARIEGATED COAT

- Combination of two or more colours
- Non-uniform fibre pigmentation

✓ Significance

- ✗ Reflects natural genetic variability
- ✗ Often seen in extensive systems



SIGNIFICANCE OF COAT COLOUR IN SHEEP

✓ Thermoregulation

- ✓ Light colours reflect heat
- ✓ Dark colours absorb heat

✗ wool Quality & Market Value

- ✓ White fleece = highest commercial value
- ✓ Coloured wool = niche / specialty markets.



FIELD NOTE

✗ Artificial colouring or cosmetic alteration is **NOT recommended**

KEY MESSAGE: "COAT COLOUR INFLUENCES HEAT TOLERANCE, WOOL VALUE, BREED IDENTITY, AND FARM MANAGEMENT."

FieldvetDrMSS



Section 5: Breeds & Genetic Resources

15. Types Of Coat Color in Sheep and Its Significance

What Is Coat Color?

Coat color in sheep is determined by:

- Genetics (melanin type & distribution)
- Breed characteristics
- Environmental adaptation

It influences heat tolerance, management, disease resistance, and economic value.

Common Types of Coat Color in Sheep

1. WHITE (Most Common & Preferred)

Characteristics

- Pure white or creamy white fleece
- Pink skin underneath

Significance

- ✓ Highly preferred for wool production
- ✓ Easy to dye into any color
- ✓ Better heat reflection
- ✓ Widely used in commercial sheep farming
- ✗ Prone to sunburn & photosensitization in extreme heat

2. BLACK

Characteristics

- Uniform black fleece
- Dark skin and hooves

Significance

- ✓ Better resistance to sunburn
- ✓ Often hardy and disease-resistant
- ✓ Preferred for natural-color wool markets
- ✗ Absorbs more heat
- ✗ Less preferred in commercial wool grading

3. BROWN / RED / TAN

Characteristics

- Light brown to dark reddish shades

- Often uneven distribution

Significance

- ✓ Strong rustic and hardy appearance
- ✓ Adapted to dry & semi-arid regions
- ✓ Preferred in meat-type indigenous breeds
- ✗ Limited demand in conventional wool industry

4. GREY

Characteristics

- Mixture of black and white fibres
- Silver-grey to dark grey shades

Significance

- ✓ Indicates genetic diversity
- ✓ Moderate heat tolerance
- ✓ Accepted in niche wool markets

5. SPOTTED / PATCHED (PIEBALD)

Characteristics

- White base with black or brown patches
- Irregular pattern

Significance

- ✓ Common in indigenous & non-descript sheep
- ✓ Useful for easy animal identification
- ✗ Lower wool uniformity
- ✗ Less commercial value for fine wool

6. MIXED / VARIEGATED COAT

Characteristics

- Combination of two or more colors
- Non-uniform fibre pigmentation

Significance

- ✓ Reflects natural genetic variability
- ✓ Often seen in extensive systems
- ✗ Poor wool grading & processing value

Significance Of Coat Color in Sheep

1. Thermoregulation

- ✓ Light colors reflect heat
- ✓ Dark colors absorb heat
- ✓ Direct impact on heat stress & productivity

2. Wool Quality & Market Value

- ✓ White fleece = highest commercial value
- ✓ Colored wool = niche / specialty markets

3. Breed Identification

- ✓ Coat color is a key breed marker

Examples:

- Marwari – White
- Nellore – White
- Deccani – Black / Brown
- Vembur – White with patches

4. Disease & Skin Protection

- ✓ Dark skin → better UV protection
- ✓ Light skin → prone to photosensitization

5. Management Advantage

- ✓ Spotted coats aid flock identification
- ✓ Color helps segregation & record keeping

Field Note

- ✗ Artificial colouring or cosmetic alteration is not recommended
- ✓ Natural coat color reflects true genetic and adaptive traits

Key Message

“Coat color influences heat tolerance, wool value, breed identity, and farm management.”

ENDANGERED SHEEP BREEDS OF INDIA

& CONSERVATION PROGRAMMES

ENDANGERED SHEEP BREEDS OF INDIA

— Threatened Indigenous Breeds —

FieldvetDrMSS

Nilgiri Sheep (Tamil Nadu)



- Fine wool breed from Nilgiris
- Declining population

Magra Sheep (Rajasthan)



- Lustrous carpet wool breed
- At risk from cross-breeding

Chokla Sheep (Rajasthan)



- **Vulnerable**; prized for fine wool
- Declining numbers

Tibetan Sheep (Sikkim)



- Himalayan breed; very rare
- Population under 250

Munjal Sheep (Northwest India)



- Local, dwindling flocks
- Not officially registered

WHY ARE THEY THREATENED?



- Crossbreeding



- Loss of Grazing Land



- Lack of market and wool demand



- Erosion of Pastoral Systems

CONSERVATION PROGRAMMES IN INDIA



ICAR-NBAGR

- National Bureau of Animal Genetic Resources
- Breed Evaluation & Awards



National/AICRP Projects

- Sheep Improvement & Breeding Research



In Situ & Ex Situ Conservation

- On-farm & Research Centre Protection



Breed Registration

- Official Recognition of Indigenous Breeds



State Govt. Initiatives

- Local Support & Development Programs



SAVE INDIA'S INDIGENOUS SHEEP HERITAGE!

FieldvetDrMSS

21. Endangered Sheep Breeds of India and Conservation Programmes

India possesses rich sheep genetic diversity, adapted to different agro-climatic zones. However, several indigenous breeds are declining due to crossbreeding, shrinking grazing lands, changing farming systems, and low economic returns. Conservation of these breeds is essential for maintaining genetic resources, climate resilience, and rural livelihoods.

❑ Nilgiri Sheep (Tamil Nadu)

Status: Endangered

Region: Nilgiri Hills, Tamil Nadu

Characteristics:

- Fine wool producing sheep
- Adapted to cool hill climates
- White fleece with good wool quality

Threats:

- Crossbreeding with exotic wool breeds
- Declining wool market
- Reduced pasture availability

Conservation Efforts:

- Breed conservation farms
- Selective breeding programmes

❑ Bombala Sheep

Region: Sikkim and Eastern Himalayan region

Characteristics:

- Medium sized sheep
- Adapted to high altitude climate
- Used for meat and coarse wool

Threats:

- Small population size
- Limited breeding programmes

❑ Gurez Sheep

Region: Kashmir Himalayan region

Characteristics:

- Fine wool producing breed
- Adapted to cold mountainous areas

Threats:

- Crossbreeding with exotic sheep
- Reduced pastoral migration routes

4 Tibetan Sheep

Region: Ladakh and high Himalayan plateau

Characteristics:

- Highly adapted to extreme cold
- Provides meat, wool, and manure

Threats:

- Changing pastoral systems
- Climate change effects

5 Poonchi Sheep

Region: Jammu & Kashmir

Characteristics:

- Medium sized dual-purpose sheep
- Meat and carpet wool production

Threats:

- Genetic dilution due to uncontrolled breeding
- Reduced grazing lands

Major Causes of Decline

- Loss of traditional grazing corridors
- Urbanization and land-use change
- Crossbreeding with exotic breeds
- Low economic value of wool
- Lack of structured breeding programme

Conservation Programmes in India**1 Breed Conservation Farms**

Government farms maintain pure breeding flocks.

Example institutions:

- ICAR – Central Sheep and Wool Research Institute
- State livestock breeding farms

2 In-Situ Conservation

- Conserving breeds within their native production systems
- Supporting shepherd communities
- Maintaining traditional grazing routes

3 Ex-Situ Conservation

- Conservation in organized farms
- Germplasm preservation
- Frozen semen and embryo banks

4 National Breed Improvement Programmes

Important initiative:

- National Livestock Mission

Focus areas:

- Breed conservation
- Genetic improvement
- Support for shepherd communities

5 Community-Based Breeding Programmes

- Participation of local farmers
- Selection of superior breeding rams
- Maintaining breed purity

Importance of Conserving Indigenous Sheep Breeds

- ✓ Climate resilience
- ✓ Disease resistance
- ✓ Adaptation to local grazing systems
- ✓ Preservation of genetic diversity
- ✓ Sustainable rural livelihoods



ENDANGERED SHEEP BREEDS OF AFRICA

& CONSERVATION PROGRAMMES

FieldvetDrMSS



ENDANGERED SHEEP BREEDS OF AFRICA

Threatened Indigenous Breeds

Red Maasai Sheep (East Africa)



- Reddish-brown, hardy porchy, disease resistant
- Declining population
- Crossbreeding with exotic

Namaqua Afrikaner (South Africa)



- Hardy, fat-tailed breed adapted to drylands
- Low population
- Lost to commercial breeds

Zambian Sheep (Zambia)



- Persisting in remote regions & various color patterns
- No conservation programs
- Population decline

Zerma/Touareg (West Africa)



- Short-haired, resilient nuer and, Mali
- Loss of grazing areas
- Lack of focused breeding programmes

WHY ARE THEY THREATENED?



- Crossbreeding
- On-farm management & community-based progs



- Loss of Grazing Land
- Cene-liakic & breeding programs



- Loss of Pastoralism
- Training, incentives & market linkages



- Lack of Conservation Support
- National policies, partnerships

CONSERVATION PROGRAMMES IN AFRICA



PROTECT AFRICA'S UNIQUE LIVESTOCK HERITAGE!



22. Endangered Sheep Breeds of Africa & Conservation Programmes

● Endangered / Threatened Sheep Breeds of Africa

1. Red Maasai Sheep (East Africa)

Kenya, Tanzania

- Indigenous hair sheep, highly resistant to gastrointestinal parasites
- Being replaced by exotic Dorper crosses
- Pure Red Maasai populations declining rapidly

2. Namaqua Afrikaner Sheep (South Africa)

Arid regions of Northern Cape

- Fat-tailed breed, well adapted to extreme drought
- Low reproductive rate and shrinking population
- Threatened due to commercial breed replacement

3. Zulu Sheep (South Africa)

- Indigenous Nguni sheep type
- Hardy, disease-tolerant, adapted to low-input systems
- Population decline due to cross-breeding and poor recognition

4. Djallonké (West African Dwarf) Sheep

West & Central Africa

- Small-sized, trypano tolerant breed
- Genetic dilution due to uncontrolled cross-breeding
- Declining in pure form despite wide distribution

5. Tuareg / Sahelian Sheep (West Africa)

Mali, Niger, Burkina Faso

- Adapted to semi-arid and desert ecosystems
- Loss of grazing lands and pastoral routes
- Lack of structured breeding and conservation plans

6. Ethiopian Highland Sheep

- Multiple local ecotypes adapted to high altitudes
- Threatened by genetic erosion and climate change
- Poor documentation and conservation coverage.

⚠ Why Are They Threatened?

- Indiscriminate cross-breeding with exotic sheep
- Loss of grazing lands and pastoral corridors

- Climate change and recurrent droughts
- Neglect of indigenous breeds in national breeding policies
- Low economic valuation of local sheep breeds

Conservation Programmes in Africa

1. FAO – Animal Genetic Resources (AnGR) Programme

- Global monitoring of endangered livestock breeds
- Supports in situ and ex situ conservation
- DAD-IS database for African sheep breeds

2. Community-Based in Situ Conservation

- On-farm conservation with pastoral and smallholder farmers
- Maintenance of pure breeding flocks
- Traditional knowledge-based breeding systems

3. National Livestock Research Institutes

- South Africa, Kenya, Ethiopia, Nigeria
- Breed characterization, performance recording
- Conservation flocks at research stations

4. Cryo-conservation & Gene Banks

- Preservation of semen, embryos and DNA
- Long-term genetic resource security
- Limited but expanding in African countries

5. NGO & University-Led Initiatives

- ILRI, AU-IBAR, local universities
- Breed surveys, awareness, farmer training
- Linking conservation with livelihood improvement

Importance of Conserving African Sheep

- Climate-resilient genetic resources
- Disease and parasite resistance
- Food security for pastoral communities
- Preservation of livestock biodiversity

Key Message

“Protect Africa’s indigenous sheep – they are key to resilient livestock systems.”

CLIMATE-SPECIFIC IDEAL SHEEP SHED DESIGN: #FieldvetDrMSS



Section 6: Farm Infrastructure & Equipment

33. Climate-Specific Ideal Sheep Shed Design

(Roof • Floor • Ventilation)

A. Dry & Semi-Arid Regions:

(Rajasthan, Telangana, Karnataka, Maharashtra)

Roof:

☒ Thatch / Clay tile / Insulated GI sheet

- High roof (ridge 12 ft)
- Wide overhang (3 ft)
- Whitewashed GI sheets

Prevents: Heat stress, dehydration, infertility.

Floor:

☒ Raised earthen floor

☒ Brick floor with slope

- Dry, well-drained
- Bedding during winter

Prevents: Foot rot, lameness.

Ventilation:

☒ Open-sided shed

☒ East–West orientation

- Maximum air flow

Prevents: Heat buildup, respiratory stress

Key Risks if Poor Design:

- ✗ Heat stress
- ✗ Reduced growth & fertility
- ✗ High water requirement

B. High Rainfall / Humid Regions:

(Kerala, Coastal India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, NE India)

Roof:

☒ Clay / Mangalore tile

✓ GI sheet with insulation

- Steep slope (35–40°)
- Leak-proof

Prevents: Pneumonia, fungal infections

Floor:

✓ Raised slatted (wood/bamboo/plastic)

- Height: 2–3 ft
- Slat gap: 1.5–2 cm

Prevents: Foot rot, parasitism, mastitis

Ventilation:

✓ Ridge ventilation

✓ Open side walls (4–5 ft)

Prevents: Humidity-related respiratory diseases

Key Risks if Poor Design:

- ✗ Foot rot
- ✗ Pneumonia
- ✗ Fly infestation

▲ C. Hilly & Cold Regions:

(Himalayas, Nepal, Bhutan, Himachal, J&K)

Roof:

✓ Tile / Thatch with insulation

- Lower roof height
- Windbreaks on sides

Prevents: Cold stress, hypothermia

Floor:

✓ Wooden / bamboo raised floor

✓ Deep litter system

- Thick dry bedding

Prevents: Joint injuries, lamb mortality

Ventilation:

- ✓ Controlled ventilation
- ✗ Avoid direct drafts

Prevents: Pneumonia

Key Risks if Poor Design:

- ✗ Hypothermia
- ✗ Lamb deaths
- ✗ Respiratory infections

 D. Temperate / Mixed Climate Regions:

(North India plains, Central Asia)

Roof:

- ✓ Tile or insulated GI
- Moderate height
- Seasonal insulation

Floor:

- ✓ Concrete with bedding
- Dry & clean

Ventilation:

- ✓ Adjustable openings
- Seasonal management

 Common Design Standards (All Regions):

Component & Ideal Specification:

Orientation - East–West

Roof height - Eaves 8–10 ft, Ridge 10–12 ft

Floor slope - 1:40

Space (adult) - 10–12 sq.ft covered

Drainage – Mandatory

 Diseases Linked to Climate-Poor Shed Design:

- Heat stress
- Pneumonia

- Foot rot
- Mastitis
- High lamb mortality
- Low productivity

□ Key Veterinary Message:

👉 There is no single ideal sheep shed for all regions.

👉 Design must match climate + management system to minimize disease and maximize productivity.

SHEEP FARM ROOF TYPES & Associated Health Disorders

FieldvetDrMSS

Thatched Roof
(Straw / Grass / Coconut Leaves)



- **Advantages:**
 - ✓ Low cost, locally available
 - ✓ Good thermal insulation (cool in summer)
 - ✓ Eco-friendly
- **Associated Health Disorders:**
 - ✗ Respiratory infections (poor ventilation, moisture)
 - ✗ Ectoparasite infestation (mites, ticks)
 - ✗ Fly breeding & vector-borne diseases
 - ✗ Allergic reactions (dust spores)
 - ✓ Best suited for: Dry areas with good ventilation
 - ✗ Not suitable for: High rainfall, humid zones

Asbestos Sheet Roof
(Legacy structures)



- **Advantages:**
 - ✓ Durable and weather resistant
 - ✓ Moderate insulation
 - ✓ **Heat stress** (poor thermal regulation)
 - ✓ **Respiratory irritation** (Fiber exposure in old/damaged sheets)
 - ✓ Reduced feed intake due to heat load
- ✗ **Human health hazard** (important occupational)
- ✗ **Veterinary Recommendation:** ★★★★★
ⓘ Gradual replacement advised

Galvanized Iron (GI) / Metal Sheet Roof



- **Advantages:**
 - ✓ Strong, long-lasting
 - ✓ Easy to install
 - ✓ Low maintenance
- **Associated Health Disorders:**
 - ✓ Severe heat stress
 - ✓ Heat-induced respiratory distress
 - ✓ Reduced growth, fertility & milk yield
 - ✓ Increased water demand & dehydration
- Veterinary Recommendation:** ✗ Gradual replacement advised

Tile Roof (Clay / Mangalore Tiles)



- **Advantages:**
 - ✓ Minimal if maintained
 - ✓ Injuries from broken tiles (rare)
- **Overall Rating:** ★★★★★★
★★★★★ ** Best for tropical climates)

Concrete Roof
(RCC / Cement Slab)



- **Advantages:**
 - ✓ Heat stress in summer
 - ✓ Poor air circulation → rare

COMPARATIVE TABLE

ROOF TYPE	MAJOR HEALTH RISKS	SUITABILITY	SUITABILITY
Thatched (Mud)	Pneumonia, parasites	Dry areas	Dry areas
Asbestos	Heat stress, lung irritation	Not recommended	Not recommended
GI Sheet	Heat stress, dehydration	With insulation	With insulation
Tile	Minimal	Highly suitable	Highly suitable
Concrete	Heat stress, pneumonia	With ventilation	With ventilation
Poly/HDPE	Minor respiratory issues	Good with airflow	Good with airflow

KEY VETERINARY MESSAGE



- ✓ Roofing directly influences thermal stress, respiratory health, **productivity, & mortality** in sheep. **Tile or insulated GI roofs with proper ventilation is best**

24. Sheep Farm Roof Types and Associated Diseases

(Key housing factor affecting sheep health)

Proper roofing in sheep sheds is essential for ventilation, temperature control, and disease prevention. Poor roofing design can lead to heat stress, respiratory infections, parasitic problems, and foot diseases in sheep flocks.

1. 🌿 Thatched Roof (Straw / Coconut Leaves / Grass)

Advantage

- Good insulation against heat
- Natural cooling in tropical climates
- Low construction cost

Associated Health Risks

- Moisture retention leading to respiratory infections
- Fungal growth causing allergic pneumonia
- Harboring ticks, mites, and rodents

Common Diseases

- Pneumonia
- Tick-borne diseases
- Skin infections

2. 🏠 Tile Roof (Clay / Country Tiles)

Advantages

- Better ventilation than metal roofs
- Moderate temperature control
- Long lifespan compared to thatch

Associated Health Risks

- Water leakage during heavy rains
- Damp bedding conditions

Common Diseases

- Foot rot
- Foot scald
- Mastitis due to wet bedding

3. 🏠 Asbestos / Fibre Cement Sheet Roof

Advantages

- Durable and affordable

- Easy installation

Associated Health Risks

- High heat accumulation in summer
- Poor air circulation if shed height is low

Common Diseases

- Heat stress
- Reduced feed intake
- Reproductive problems

4. Metal Sheet Roof (GI / Aluminium)

Advantages

- Long-lasting and strong
- Resistant to heavy rain

Associated Health Risks

- Extreme heat radiation in tropical regions
- Condensation causing moisture

Common Diseases

- Heat stroke
- Respiratory diseases
- Dehydration

5. Eco-Friendly Roof (Bamboo / Agroforestry Shade + Roof)

Advantages

- Excellent ventilation
- Natural cooling effect
- Environmentally sustainable

Associated Health Risks

- If poorly maintained, may allow insects and predators
- Possible Diseases
- Vector-borne diseases (ticks, flies) if hygiene is poor

General Diseases Linked to Poor Sheep Housing

- Pneumonia
- Foot rot and foot scald
- Mastitis
- Parasitic infestations (ticks, mites, lice)

- Heat stress and dehydration

☐ Ideal Sheep Shed Roof Recommendations

- ✓ Height: 10–12 ft for proper ventilation
- ✓ Roof slope: 20–30° for rainwater drainage
- ✓ East–West orientation to reduce sunlight exposure
- ✓ Overhang of 3–4 ft to protect from rain

- ☑ Best practical combination in tropical regions:

Tile or insulated metal roof with good ventilation and raised flooring.

Portable Modern Farm Equipment

Useful to Shepherds & Sheep Farmers

FieldvetDrMSS

1. Smart Monitoring Devices

✓ GPS Livestock Tracker

Real-time flock tracking



✓ RFID Ear Tag Reader

Digital animal identification



✓ Mobile-based Livestock Management Apps



✓ Handheld Weather Meter

temperature & humidity



+ Portable Health Equipment

✓ Digital Veterinary Thermometer



✓ Portable Ultrasound Scanner

– Pregnancy diagnosis



✓ Automatic Vaccination Gun



✓ Battery-operated Clipper

– Shearing & wound prep



✓ Portable Nebulizer

(respiratory therapy)



Productivity & Performance Tools

✓ Portable Electronic Weighing Scale



✓ Milk Measuring Jar (for dairy sheep)



✓ Portable Fodder Chopper



Productivity & Performance Tools

✓ Portable Electronic Weighing Scale



✓ Body Condition Scoring Chart



✓ Milk Measuring Jar (for dairy sheep)



✓ Portable Fodder Chopper



Power & Utility Equipment

✓ Solar-powered Electric Fencing Kit



✓ Portable Solar Charger / Power Bank



✓ LED Headlamp (night lambing)



✓ Portable Water Pump

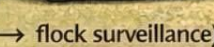


Pasture & Grazing Management

✓ Portable Water Trough



✓ Foldable Feeding Trough



✓ Drone (large-scale farms → flock surveillance)

✓ Portable Mineral Mixture Dispenser



Benefits of Modern Portable Equipment

✓ Early disease detection

✓ Reduced flock mortality

✓ Time & Labor saving

✓ Improved breeding efficiency

✓ Better pasture management

Key Message

Modern portable tools empower shepherds to practice scientific & profitable sheep farming.

Fieldvet

FieldvetDrMSS

By #Fieldvet | Field-Based Veterinary Education

25. Portable Modern Farm Equipments

Useful to Shepherds & Sheep Farmers:

1. Smart Monitoring Devices:

- ✓ GPS Livestock Tracker – Real-time flock tracking
- ✓ RFID Ear Tag Reader – Digital animal identification
- ✓ Mobile-based Livestock Management Apps
- ✓ Handheld Weather Meter – Temperature & humidity

2. Portable Health Equipments:

- ✓ Digital Veterinary Thermometer
- ✓ Portable Ultrasound Scanner – Pregnancy diagnosis
- ✓ Automatic Vaccination Gun
- ✓ Battery-operated Clipper – Shearing & wound prep
- ✓ Portable Nebulizer (respiratory therapy)

3. Productivity & Performance Tools:

- ✓ Portable Electronic Weighing Scale
- ✓ Body Condition Scoring Chart
- ✓ Milk Measuring Jar (for dairy sheep)
- ✓ Portable Fodder Chopper

4. Reproductive Management Equipment:

- ✓ Breeding Marking Harness (Ram)
- ✓ Semen Collection Artificial Vagina (advanced farms)
- ✓ Portable AI Kit (trained personnel use)
- ✓ Lambing Assistance Kit

5. Power & Utility Equipment:

- ✓ Solar-powered Electric Fencing Kit
- ✓ Portable Solar Charger / Power Bank
- ✓ LED Headlamp (night lambing)
- ✓ Portable Water Pump

6. Pasture & Grazing Management:

- ✓ Portable Water Trough
- ✓ Foldable Feeding Trough
- ✓ Drone (large-scale farms – flock surveillance)
- ✓ Portable Mineral Mixture Dispenser

Benefits of Modern Portable Equipment:

- ✓ Early disease detection
- ✓ Reduced flock mortality
- ✓ Improved breeding efficiency
- ✓ Better pasture management
- ✓ Increased profitability
- ✓ Time & labour saving

Key Message:

Modern portable tools empower shepherds to practice scientific & profitable sheep farming.

Automated Milking Machines for Sheep



Meta AI

26. Automated Milking Machines for Sheep

Technology for Efficient & Welfare-Friendly Milk Production

What Are Automated Milking Machines?

Automated milking machines (AMS) for sheep are mechanized milking systems that use vacuum, pulsation, and teat cups to hygienically extract milk with minimal human intervention, ensuring consistency, efficiency, and animal comfort.

Key Components of Sheep Milking Systems

- Teat cups (small-ruminant specific liners)
- Vacuum pump & pulsator
- Milk claw & milk lines
- Milk collection jar / pipeline
- Automatic cluster remover
- Milk cooling & storage unit
- Control panel / sensors (advanced systems)

How Automated Milking Works

1. Sheep enter milking stand / parlour
2. Teats are cleaned (manual or automated)
3. Teat cups attached
4. Controlled vacuum & pulsation extract milk
5. Automatic detachment after milk flow drops
6. Milk transferred to cooling tank

Types of Automated Milking Systems for Sheep

Portable Milking Machines

- Small flocks
- Low investment
- Suitable for semi-intensive systems

Fixed Parlour Systems

- Herringbone / parallel parlours
- Medium to large flocks
- Higher throughput

Fully Robotic Milking Systems (Advanced)

- Voluntary milking
- Individual animal monitoring

- Precision dairy farming

✓ Advantages of Automated Milking in Sheep

☐ 1. Improved Milking Efficiency

- Faster milking
- Uniform milk let-down
- Reduced milking time per animal

☐ 2. Better Milk Hygiene & Quality

- Reduced contamination
- Lower bacterial count
- Consistent milk handling

☐ 3. Labour Saving

- Reduces manual labour dependency
- Ideal for labour-scarce regions
- Improves farm scalability

☐ 4. Animal Welfare Benefits

- Gentle, controlled milking
- Reduced teat injury
- Less stress compared to hand milking

☐ 5. Increased Milk Yield

- Complete milk extraction
- Regular milking intervals
- Better udder health

☐ Impact on Udder Health

- ✓ Reduced mastitis incidence (with proper hygiene)
- ✓ Early detection using milk sensors
- ✓ Improved teat condition

⚠ Limitations & Challenges

- High initial investment
- Requires electricity & maintenance
- Skilled operation needed
- Not economical for very small flocks
- Improper settings can cause teat damage

□ Important Operating Parameters

- Vacuum level: Lower than cattle (sheep-specific)
- Pulsation ratio: Optimized for small teats
- Regular liner replacement
- Strict cleaning & sanitation protocol

□ Biosecurity & Hygiene Measures

- Pre- and post-milking teat disinfection
- Regular machine cleaning (CIP)
- Milk quality testing
- Mastitis screening

In Scope in Indian Sheep Farming

High potential in:

- Organized sheep dairies
- Milk-oriented breeds (e.g., exotic dairy sheep)
- Research farms & cooperatives
- Supports value-added products (sheep milk cheese, yogurt)

Animal Welfare Message

Properly managed automated milking improves productivity without compromising sheep welfare.

□ Key Takeaway

Right machine + right settings + good hygiene = efficient, profitable sheep milking

sheep Feeding Schedule for Breeding Sheep



Meta AI

Section 7: Feeding & Nutrition

27. Feeding Schedule for Breeding Sheep

Pre-Breeding Period (Flushing)

 3–4 weeks before mating

Objective: Improve ovulation rate & conception

- Grazing: Good quality pasture / green fodder (6–8 hrs/day)
- Concentrate: 250–300 g/ewe/day
- Maize / Barley – 40%
- Oil cake (Groundnut / Soybean) – 30%
- Bran – 28%
- Mineral mixture – 2%
- Clean drinking water: Ad libitum
- Mineral lick: Free access

 Result: Higher conception and twinning rate

Breeding Period (Mating):

 30–45 days

Objective: Maintain body condition & fertility

- Grazing: Good pasture
- Concentrate:
- Ewes: 200–250 g/day
- Rams: 400–500 g/day
- Green fodder: 1–2 kg/day (if stall fed)
- Common salt: 10 g/day

 **Avoid sudden feed changes**

Early Pregnancy (0–50 Days):

Objective: Maintain pregnancy

- Grazing: Normal grazing
- Dry fodder: 300–500 g/day
- Concentrate: 150–200 g/day
- Mineral mixture: 10 g/day

 Avoid overfeeding (risk of embryonic loss)

4 Mid Pregnancy (50–100 Days):

Objective: Foetal growth & ewe maintenance

- Grazing: Good quality
- Green fodder: 1–1.5 kg/day
- Concentrate: 200–250 g/day
- Mineral mixture: 10–15 g/day

5 Late Pregnancy (Last 6 Weeks):

Objective: Prevent pregnancy toxemia & ensure healthy lambs

- Green fodder: 2–3 kg/day
- Dry fodder: 0.5 kg/day
- Concentrate: 300–400 g/day
- Mineral mixture: 15–20 g/day
- Clean water: Unlimited

 **Do not allow fasting**

 **Divide concentrate into 2 feedings**

6 Post-Lambing / Lactation:

Objective: Support milk production & ewe recovery

- Green fodder: 3–4 kg/day
- Dry fodder: 0.5–1 kg/day
- Concentrate:
- Single lamb: 400 g/day
- Twins: 600–700 g/day
- Mineral mixture: 20 g/day

Key Feeding Tips:

- ✓ Body Condition Score (BCS): Maintain 2.5–3.5
- ✓ Provide vitamin A, D & E supplementation
- ✓ Deworm before breeding
- ✓ Avoid mouldy or spoiled feed



28. Standard Drinking Water Quality Requirements for a Sheep Farm

1. Physical Parameters

- Colour: Clear, colourless
- Odour: No foul or chemical smell
- Taste: Pleasant, no metallic or saline taste
- Turbidity: < 5 NTU (low turbidity ensures no suspended impurities)
- Total Dissolved Solids (TDS):
- Ideal: < 1,000 mg/L
- Acceptable for sheep: up to 3,000 mg/L
- >5,000 mg/L: Risky — may reduce intake, cause diarrhoea

2. Chemical Parameters:

- pH: 6.5 – 8.5
- Nitrates (NO_3^-): < 100 mg/L
- Nitrites (NO_2^-): < 10 mg/L
- Sulphates: < 1,000 mg/L (high levels → diarrhoea)
- Chlorides: < 500 mg/L
- Hardness: < 300 mg/L
- Fluoride: < 2 mg/L
- Iron: < 0.3 mg/L
- Copper: < 0.5 mg/L
- Lead: < 0.01 mg/L
- Arsenic: < 0.05 mg/L
- Ammonia: < 1 mg/L
- Sodium: < 800 mg/L

3. Biological/Microbiological Standards:

- Total Bacterial Count: As low as possible
- Total Coliforms: 0 per 100 mL
- E. coli: 0 per 100 mL
- Salmonella: Absent
- Protozoa (Giardia, Cryptosporidium): Absent

4. Additional Parameters to Monitor:

- Pesticide residues: Should be absent
- Heavy metals: As per WHO/FAO livestock limits
- Water Temperature: 10–20°C preferred
- Warm/stagnant water reduces intake
- Total Alkalinity: < 200 mg/L

5. Sources & Hygiene Requirements:

- Prefer borewell or treated surface water
- Regular cleaning of water troughs (every 2–3 days)
- Maintain clean surroundings to avoid contamination
- Prevent faecal contamination by proper trough placement
- Use chlorination when needed:
- 2–4 ppm free chlorine residual after 30 minutes

6. Signs of Poor Water Quality in Sheep:

- Reduced water intake
- Decreased feed intake
- Weight loss, poor wool growth
- Diarrhoea
- Increased disease incidence
- Reproductive failure

Sudden deaths in extreme contamination.

Sheep Rearing Exclusively on Concentrate Feed

FieldvetDrMSS

Introduction

Some intensive sheep farms rear animals entirely on concentrate feed with minimal or no grazing. This approach improves growth rate, but comes with nutritional, economic and welfare implications

✓ Merits

1. Faster Growth Rate

High-energy, high-protein feeds improve weight gain and shorten finishing period

2. Predictable Nutrition

Balanced rations ensure uniform intake of energy, protein, minerals, and vitamins

3. Suitable for Zero-Grazing Systems

Ideal where pasture is limited or unavailable.

Useful during drought, floods, or severe winters

4. Better Health Monitoring

Animals kept in sheds are easier to observe for illness, injury or lameness

5. Higher Meat Yield & Carcass Quality

Uniform body condition and improved muscle development.

6. Reduced Exposure to Pasture-Based Parasites

Lower risk of internal parasites (eg. *Haemonchus*, *Trichostrongylus*)

Practical Recommendations

Provide 10–15% roughage to maintain rumen health.
Use buffers like sodium bicarbonate to prevent acidosis.
Ensure Ca:P ratio = 2:1 to prevent urinary calculi.

✗ Demerits

1. Higher Cost of Production

Concentrates are expensive.
Profit margin decreases if feed prices rise.

2. Nutritional Disorders

Acidosis from high-grain diets
Urinary calculi in rams/wethers → mineral imbalance
Enterotoxaemia risk (increases)
Bloat due to poor ration balance

3. Poor Rumen Health

Reduced roughage decreases rumen motility and microbial diversity.
Long-term concentrate feeding may cause rumen parakeratosis.

4. Behavioural Issues

Sheep naturally prefer grazing; confinement may cause stress, boredom, wool biting, and aggression.

5. Higher Disease Risk in Housing

Pneumonia, foot problems and contagious diseases spread faster in dense housing systems

6. Low Omega-3 and PUF Levels

Meat from concentrate-fed sheep has lower omega-3 fatty acids compared to pasture-fed animals

7. Manure Accumulation: Increased need for cleaning, bedding.

29. Sheep Rearing Exclusively on Concentrate Feed

Merits and Demerits:

Introduction

Some intensive sheep farms rear animals entirely on concentrate feed with minimal or no grazing. This approach improves growth rate but comes with nutritional, economic, and welfare implications.

Merits

1. Faster Growth Rate

- High-energy, high-protein feeds improve weight gain and shorten finishing period.

2. Predictable Nutrition

- Balanced rations ensure uniform intake of energy, protein, minerals, and vitamins.
- Reduces variability seen in grazing conditions.

3. Suitable for Zero-Grazing Systems

- Ideal where pasture is limited or unavailable.
- Useful during drought, floods, or severe winters.

4. Better Health Monitoring

- Animals kept in sheds are easier to observe for illness, injury, or lameness.

5. Higher Meat Yield & Carcass Quality

- Uniform body condition and improved muscle development.

6. Reduced Exposure to Pasture-Based Parasites

- Lower risk of internal parasites (e.g., *Haemonchus*, *Trichostrongylus*).

Demerits

1. Higher Cost of Production

- Concentrates are expensive.
- Profit margin decreases if feed prices rise.

2. Nutritional Disorders

- Acidosis from high-grain diets.
- Urinary calculi in rams/weathers due to mineral imbalance.

- Enterotoxaemia risk increases.
- Bloat due to poor ration balance.

3. Poor Rumen Health

- Reduced roughage decreases rumen motility and microbial diversity.
- Long-term concentrate feeding may cause rumen parakeratosis.

4. Behavioural Issues

- Sheep naturally prefer grazing; confinement may cause stress, boredom, wool biting, and aggression.

5. Higher Disease Risk in Housing

- Pneumonia, foot problems, and contagious diseases spread faster in dense housing systems.

6. Low Omega-3 and PUFA Levels

- Meat from concentrate-fed sheep has lower omega-3 fatty acids compared to pasture-fed animals.

7. Manure Accumulation

Increased need for cleaning, bedding, and waste disposal management.

Practical Recommendations

- Provide 10–15% roughage to maintain rumen health.
- Use buffers like sodium bicarbonate to prevent acidosis.
- Ensure Ca:P ratio = 2:1 to prevent urinary calculi.
- Vaccinate for enterotoxaemia (*Clostridium perfringens* type D).
- Maintain clean housing with adequate ventilation.
- Provide ad lib clean drinking water.

Introduce concentrates gradually to avoid digestive upset.

OPTIMUM NITRATE LEVEL IN PLANTS & ITS IMPACT ON HEALTH STATUS OF SHEEP

FieldvetDrMSS

WHAT ARE NITRATES?

- Nitrates (NO_3^-) are natural nitrogen compounds in plants
- In the rumen, nitrates $\Rightarrow$ nitrites (NO_2^-)
- Excess nitrites reduce oxygen transport in blood



OPTIMUM & TOXIC LEVELS OF NITRATE IN FODDER

Nitrate Level (ppm NO_3^-)	Status	Effect on Sheep
< 1,000	Safe	No adverse effects
1,000–2,500	Generally Safe	Safe for healthy, non-pregnant sheep
2,500–5,000	Caution	Reduced growth & productivity
5,000–10,000	Dangerous	Clinical toxicity likely
> 10,000	Highly Toxic	Acute poisoning & death

⚠ Nitrite (NO_2^-) > 1,000 ppm = Severe Toxicity

COMMON HIGH-NITRATE FODDERS



FACTORS INCREASING NITRATE ACCUMULATION



IMPACT ON SHEEP HEALTH

Subclinical Effects

- Reduced Feed Intake
- Poor Weight Gain
- Low Wool Quality
- Reduced Immunity
- Poor Reproduction

Clinical Signs

- Rapid Breathing
- Muscle Tremors
- Bluish Mucous
- Weakness
- Sudden Death

Reproductive Effects

- Abortions
- Stillbirths
- Weak Lambs
- Reduced Conception

DIAGNOSIS

- History & Symptoms
- Chocolate Blood
- Forage & Water Testing

PREVENTION & CONTROL

- Test Fodder
- Avoid Hungry Grazing
- Introduce Gradually
- Mix With Hay
- Limit Nitrogen Use
- Provide Safe Water

EMERGENCY TREATMENT

- Methylene Blue IV
- Remove Toxic Feed

FieldvetDrMSS

"Green fodder is not always safe – test nitrates to protect your flock."

30. Optimum Level of Nitrate in Plants & Its Impact on Sheep Health

What are Nitrates?

- Nitrates (NO_3^-) are naturally occurring nitrogen compounds in plants
- Converted to nitrites (NO_2^-) in the rumen of sheep
- Excess nitrites cause methemoglobinemia → oxygen deprivation

Optimum & Risk Levels of Nitrate in Fodder Plants:

Nitrate Level (ppm NO_3^-), Interpretation & Effect on Sheep:

- < 1,000 ppm—>Safe—>No adverse effect
- 1,000–2,500 ppm—>Generally safe—>Safe for non-pregnant, healthy sheep
- 2,500–5,000 ppm—>Caution—>Reduced productivity, stress
- 5,000–10,000 ppm—>Dangerous—>Toxicity signs likely
- 10,000 ppm—>Highly toxic—>Acute nitrate poisoning, death.

Equivalent risk threshold:

- Nitrite (NO_2^-) > 1,000 ppm → Severe toxicity.

Common High-Nitrate Forages

- Sorghum
- Pearl millet (Bajra)
- Maize (especially drought-stressed)
- Oats
- Sudan grass
- Chenopodium, pigweed
- Young lush grasses after heavy nitrogen fertilization

Factors Increasing Nitrate Accumulation

- Excess nitrogen fertilizer
- Drought stress
- Cloudy weather / low sunlight
- Immature or fast-growing plants
- Frost damage
- High nitrate water + forage combination

Impact on Health Status of Sheep

Subclinical Effects

- Reduced feed intake
- Poor growth rate
- Decreased wool quality
- Reduced fertility

- Lower immunity

Clinical Nitrate Poisoning

- Rapid breathing
- Muscle tremors
- Excess salivation
- Blue/brown mucous membranes
- Weakness, staggering
- Sudden death in severe cases

Reproductive Effects

- Abortion
- Stillbirth
- Weak lambs
- Reduced conception rate

Pathophysiology (Simplified)

Nitrate → Nitrite (rumen)

Nitrite → Converts hemoglobin to methemoglobin

↓

Blood cannot carry oxygen

↓

Tissue hypoxia → death

Diagnosis

- History of feeding lush/high-risk forage
- Brownish blood (chocolate colored)
- Forage nitrate testing
- Water nitrate analysis

Prevention & Control

- ✓ Test suspect fodder before feeding
- ✓ Avoid grazing hungry sheep on lush forage
- ✓ Gradual adaptation to high-risk feeds
- ✓ Dilute high-nitrate fodder with safe roughage
- ✓ Prefer hay over fresh fodder (drying reduces nitrates)
- ✓ Avoid heavy nitrogen fertilization before grazing

- ☑ Ensure clean, low-nitrate drinking water

Emergency Treatment:

- Methylene Blue (1% solution) IV
- Supportive therapy
- Remove toxic feed immediately

Key Message for Farmers:

“Green does not always mean safe – test fodder to protect your flock.”



SHEEP FARMING

GRAZING MANAGEMENT — BASICS

1 Importance of Grazing Management

- Reduces feed cost (major production expense)
- Improves animal health & productivity
- Maintains pasture sustainability
- Controls internal parasites



2 Grazing Behaviour of Sheep

- Sheep are selective grazers
- Prefer:
 - Short, tender grasses
 - Legumes and forbs

 **Graze close to ground**
Higher parasite risk if unmanaged



3 Types of Grazing Systems

Continuous Grazing

- Animals graze same pasture continuously
- Simple, low-cost

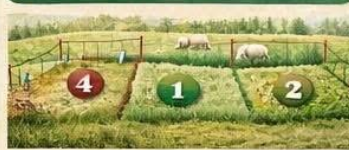
 Leads to overgrazing & pasture degradation



Rotational Grazing (recommended)

- Pasture divided into paddocks
- Animals moved periodically

- ✓ Better forage use
- ✓ Reduced parasite load
- ✓ Improved pasture recovery



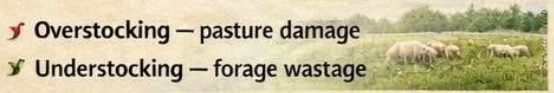
Strip Grazing

- Daily controlled access using fencing
- High efficiency
- Suitable for intensive systems



4 Stocking Rate

- Number of sheep per unit area
- Depends on
 - Forage availability
 - Rainfall
 - Soil fertility

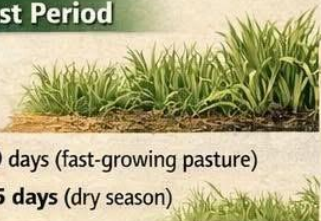


 Overstocking — pasture damage

 Understocking — forage wastage

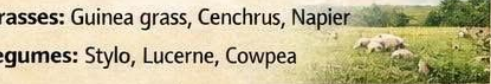
5 Grazing & Rest Period

- Start: 15~20 cm
- Stop: 5~7 cm
- Rest period: 21~30 days (fast-growing pasture)
30~45 days (dry season)



6 Pasture Types for Sheep

- Grasses: Guinea grass, Cenchrus, Napier
- Legumes: Stylo, Lucerne, Cowpea



7 Water & Shade Management

- Clean drinking water
- Rotate paddocks regularly
- Match stocking rate to pasture
- Maintain pasture diversity



10 Key Grazing Management Tips

- Prevent overgrazing
- Rotate paddocks regularly
- Match stocking rate to pasture
- Observe animals daily



Healthy Pasture = Healthy Sheep = Higher Profit

#Fieldvet

Section 8: Grazing & Sustainable Practices

31. Sheep Farming – Grazing Management Basics

1. Importance of Grazing Management

Proper grazing management improves:

- Animal nutrition
- Pasture sustainability
- Parasite control
- Sheep productivity
- Soil and ecosystem health

Good grazing practices can reduce feed costs by 40–60% in sheep farming systems.

2. Types of Grazing Systems

Continuous Grazing

- Sheep graze the same pasture throughout the season
- Easy management but may cause overgrazing

Rotational Grazing

- Pasture divided into paddocks
- Sheep moved periodically
- Allows grass regrowth and parasite reduction

Strip Grazing

- Sheep graze a small strip daily using electric fencing
- Improves forage utilization

Deferred Grazing

- Pasture rested for future seasonal use

3. Ideal Pasture Plants for Sheep

Common nutritious pasture species:

Grasses - Ryegrass, Bermuda grass, Orchard grass, Timothy grass.

Legumes - Clover, Alfalfa, Stylosanthes, Lucerne.

Legumes improve protein and soil nitrogen levels.

4. Grazing Height Management

Forage Type	Start Grazing	Stop Grazing
Ryegrass	15–20 cm	5–7 cm

Clover	12–15 cm	4–5 cm
Bermuda grass	10–15 cm	4 cm

Maintaining proper height prevents pasture damage and improves regrowth.

5. Stocking Density

Stocking rate depends on:

- Rainfall
- Soil fertility
- Pasture productivity

Typical stocking density:

- 5–8 sheep per acre (good pasture)
- 2–4 sheep per acre (dry areas)

Overstocking leads to:

- Pasture degradation
- Increased parasite burden
- Poor animal growth

6. Seasonal Grazing Management

Summer

- Provide shade and water
- Avoid grazing during peak heat

Monsoon

- Rotate grazing frequently
- Prevent muddy pasture damage

Winter

- Supplement hay and silage
- Use deferred pastures

7. Parasite Control Through Grazing

Good grazing management helps control parasites.

Methods:

- Rotational grazing
- Mixed grazing with cattle
- Pasture resting for 30–60 days
- Avoid grazing very short grass (<3 cm)

- Short pasture increases worm larvae ingestion.

8. Water and Mineral Access

Sheep require:

- 4–8 litres water/day
- Salt licks
- Mineral mixture
- Place water points in multiple pasture areas.

9. Pasture Improvement Methods

- Reseeding improved grasses
- Controlled fertilization
- Weed management
- Silvopasture integration
- Soil conservation
- Healthy pastures support higher lamb growth and wool yield.

10. Benefits of Good Grazing Management

- ✓ Better flock health
- ✓ Higher lamb survival
- ✓ Reduced feed costs
- ✓ Sustainable pasture use
- ✓ Improved soil fertility

Field Tip for Shepherds:

“Move sheep before pasture becomes too short – healthy grass means healthy sheep.”

GRAZING PATTERNS OF SHEEP & DISEASE OCCURRENCE

FieldvetDrMSS

1. Continuous Grazing

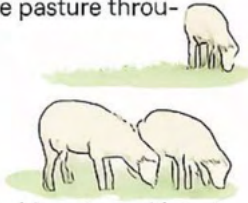
Animals graze the same pasture throughout the season.

Disease Link:

- Higher parasite load (Haemonchus, Trichostrongylus).
- Increased risk of foot problems in muddy / wet patches
- More chances of coccidiosis in young stock

Reason:

- Continuous exposure to infective larvae and contaminated pasture



2. Rotational Grazing

Pasture divided into paddocks. Sheep moved periodically.

Disease Link:

- Reduced gastrointestinal parasites.
- Lower incidence of bacterial diseases linked to dampness/fouling.
- Helps break life cycle of lungworms and cestodes.

Reason: Rest periods allow larvae to die off; better pasture hygiene.



3. Strip Grazing

Sheep allowed to graze a small strip at a time.

Disease Link:

- Controlled intake reduces risk of bloat.
- Useful in preventing overgrazing-diseases

If poorly managed → accumulation of fecal matter → parasite hotspots.

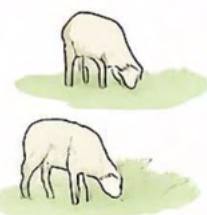


4. Free-Range / Extensive Grazing

Sheep roams large open ranges.

Disease Link:

- Low parasite burdens due to wide dispersion.
- Higher exposure to vector-borne diseases (bluetongue from Culicoides, tick-borne diseases).
- Possible poisoning due to access to unknown plants.



5. Zero-Grazing / Stall Feeding

Sheep kept in sheds and fed cut fodder

Disease Link:

- Drestically reduced parasite infection
- Increased risk of respiratory diseases (PPR: pneumonia)



7. Night Grazing

Grazing at night, common in hot climates

Disease Link:

- Increased tick exposure
- Higher risk from predators leading to stress.
- Moisture-rich grasses may predispose to bloat.



Disease Risk Factors Related to Grazing

- Moisture & Temperature: Promote parasite development.
- Overstocking: Increases fecal contamination.

Pasture Type: Low-lying areas → liver fluke; wet areas → foot rot.

KEY PREVENTIVE MEASURES

- ✓ Scheduled deworming based on FEC (fecal egg count)
- ✓ Avoid overgrazing; maintain pasture height > 5 cm
- ✓ Practice rotational grazing (30–45 days rest)
- ✓ Provide clean, dry resting places

32. Grazing Patterns of Sheep & Disease Occurrence

1. Continuous Grazing:

Pattern: Animals graze the same pasture throughout the season.

Disease Link:

- Higher parasite load (Haemonchus, Trichostrongylus).
- Increased risk of foot problems in muddy/wet patches.
- More chances of coccidiosis in young stock.

Reason: Continuous exposure to infective larvae and contaminated pasture.

2. Rotational Grazing:

Pattern: Pasture divided into paddocks; animals moved periodically.

Disease Link:

- Reduced gastrointestinal parasites.
- Lower incidence of bacterial diseases linked to dampness/fouling.
- Helps break life cycle of lungworms and cestodes.

Reason: Rest periods allow larvae to die off; better pasture hygiene.

3. Strip Grazing:

Pattern: Sheep allowed to graze a small strip at a time.

Disease Link:

- Controlled intake reduces risk of bloat.
- Useful in preventing overgrazing-linked diseases.
- If poorly managed → accumulation of fecal matter → parasite hotspots.

4. Free-Range / Extensive Grazing:

Pattern: Sheep roam large open ranges.

Disease Link:

- Low parasite burdens due to wide dispersion.
- Higher exposure to vector-borne diseases (bluetongue from Culicoides, tick-borne diseases).
- Possible poisoning due to access to unknown plants.

5. Zero-Grazing / Stall Feeding:

Pattern: Sheep kept in sheds and fed cut fodder.

Disease Link:

- Drastically reduced parasite infection.
- Increased risk of respiratory diseases (PPR, pneumonia).

- Higher chances of feed-related disorders (acidosis, bloat).

6. Night Grazing:

Pattern: Grazing at night, common in hot climates.

Disease Link:

- Increased tick exposure.
- Higher risk from predators leading to stress.
- Moisture-rich grasses may predispose to bloat.

7. High-Density or Tether Grazing:

Pattern: Close grouping or tethering in small areas.

Disease Link:

- Rapid contamination → heavy worm burden.
- Spread of infectious foot conditions (foot rot, foot scald).
- Higher contact rate → respiratory outbreaks.

Disease Risk Factors Related to Grazing:

- Moisture & Temperature: Promote parasite development.
- Overstocking: Increases fecal contamination.
- Pasture Type: Low-lying areas → liver fluke; wet areas → foot rot.
- Season: Monsoon & early winter → highest parasite load.

Key Preventive Measures:

- ✓ Scheduled deworming based on FEC (faecal egg count)
- ✓ Avoid overgrazing; maintain pasture height > 5 cm
- ✓ Practice rotational grazing (30–45 days rest)
- ✓ Provide clean, dry resting places
- ✓ Manage stocking density
- ✓ Strategic flukicide use in fluke-prone areas
- ✓ Tick and insect vector control measures

PASTURE SPELLING TO CONTROL TICK INFESTATION

In Sheep Flocks

FieldvetDrMSS



WHAT IS PASTURE SPELLING?

• Pasture spelling is the practice of resting land for a defined period to **break the life cycle** of ticks by depriving them of hosts.



TICK LIFE CYCLE (KEY POINT)

- Eggs → Larvae → Nymphs
- Effective against: Larvae
- Best suited for: Light infestation



WHY PASTURE SPELLING WORKS

Ticks require:

- A host animal for blood meal
- Suitable **microclimate** (humidity & vegetation cover)

- ✎ Removing sheep from pasture leads to
- ✎ Death of larvae and nymphs
- ✎ Failure of egg hatching
- ✎ Reduction in environmental tick load



1 SHORT-TERM PASTURE SPELLING

- ✓ Duration: 2–4 weeks
- ✓ Effective against: Larvae
- ✓ Best suited for: Light infestation



2 MEDIUM-TERM PASTURE SPELLING

- ✓ Duration: 6–9 weeks
- ✓ Effective against: Larvae & nymphs
- ✓ Recommended for: Moderate infestation



3 LONG-TERM PASTURE SPELLING

- ✓ Duration: 3–6 months
- ✓ Effective against: All life stages
- ✓ Recommended for: Heavy infestation / extensive pastures

RECOMMENDED METHODS (GENERAL GUIDE)

- | | |
|-----------------|------------|
| • Rhipicephalus | 6–9 weeks |
| • Haemaphysalis | 8–12 weeks |
| • Hyalomma | 3–4 months |
| • Ixodes | 2–3 months |

(May vary with climate and vegetation)



KEY FIELD MESSAGE

- ✓ Pasture spelling + acaricide treatment + good management = effective tick control



ROTATIONAL GRAZING SYSTEM

- ✓ Divide pasture into multiple paddocks
- ✓ Graze one paddock while others are rested
- ✓ Maintain minimum rest period based on tick season
- ✓ Sustainable and cost-effective control



ADVANTAGES OF PASTURE SPELLING

- ✓ Reduces tick population naturally
- ✓ Minimizes acaricide use
- ✓ Delays resistance development
- ✓ Environment-friendly

CONCLUSION: Pasture spelling is a cost-effective, sustainable, and eco-friendly method that plays a vital role in integrated tick management in Sheep Flocks

Oie
NATURAL PRETORIOS
DEPARTAMENTO DE
OIE
WOAH

33. Pasture Spelling to Control Tick Infestation in Sheep Flocks

Pasture spelling is a strategic grazing management practice where a pasture is rested (kept free of animals) for a specific period to break the life cycle of ticks and other parasites. It is an effective non-chemical control method for managing tick infestations in sheep flocks.

What is Pasture Spelling?

Pasture spelling means temporarily removing sheep from a grazing area so that parasites such as ticks cannot find a host and eventually die. Ticks require animal hosts to complete their life cycle, and when the pasture remains ungrazed, many ticks fail to survive.

How Pasture Spelling Controls Ticks

Tick life cycle stages:

- Egg
- Larva
- Nymph
- Adult

Without a host animal:

- Larvae cannot attach and feed
- Nymphs fail to develop
- Adult ticks die without reproduction

→ **Result:** Natural reduction of tick population in pasture

Recommended Pasture Spelling Duration

- 3–6 months resting period depending on climate
- In hot and dry regions, ticks die faster
- In humid regions, longer spelling may be required

Pasture Rotation Strategy

Example rotational grazing plan:

Pasture	Grazing Period	Rest Period
Pasture A	2–3 weeks	2–3 months
Pasture B	2–3 weeks	2–3 months
Pasture C	2–3 weeks	2–3 months

This helps break the parasite life cycle continuously.

☐ Additional Benefits of Pasture Spelling

- ✓ Reduces tick and parasite burden
- ✓ Improves pasture regrowth and forage quality
- ✓ Reduces reliance on acaricides
- ✓ Helps delay acaricide resistance
- ✓ Promotes sustainable sheep farming

⚠ Integrated Tick Control Measures

Pasture spelling works best when combined with:

- Strategic acaricide treatment
- Regular flock inspection
- Rotational grazing
- Pasture management
- Breed selection for tick resistance

☐ Veterinary Recommendation

Pasture spelling should be part of an Integrated Parasite Management (IPM) program for sheep flocks, helping farmers reduce chemical usage and improve flock health.

Sheep Rearing and Regenerative Farming

A Sustainable Approach to Livestock Production

FieldvetDrMSS

Sheep rearing plays a vital role in **regenerative farming systems**, where livestock are integrated to **restore soil health, enhance biodiversity, and improve farm resilience** while maintaining productivity.



What is Regenerative Farming?

Regenerative farming is a system of agriculture that aims to:

- Restore soil organic matter
- Improve ecosystem health
- Enhance water retention and carbon sequestration
- Reduce dependence on external inputs

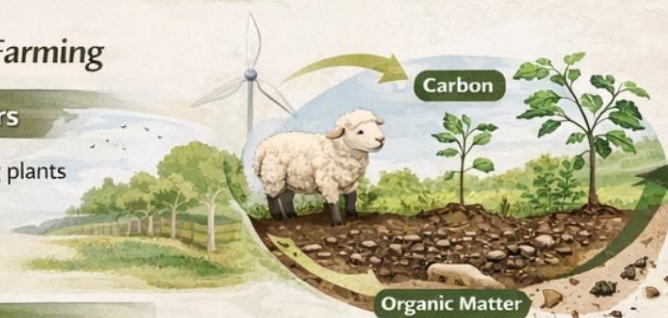


✓ Sheep are one of the **most suitable livestock species** for regenerative systems.

Role of Sheep in Regenerative Farming

1. Natural Grazers and Soil Builders

- ✓ Sheep graze selectively without uprooting plants
- ✓ Promote uniform pasture utilization
- ✓ Hoof action aids seed incorporation and soil aeration



2. Nutrient Cycling Through Manure

- ✓ Sheep dung and urine act as organic fertilizers
- ✓ Enhance microbial activity in soil
- ✓ Improve nitrogen and phosphorus availability

3. Controlled Grazing (Rotational Grazing)

- ✓ Sheep are moved between paddocks
- ✓ Prevents overgrazing
- ✓ Allows pasture recovery



4. Weed and Bush Control

- ✓ Sheep consume weeds and invasive plants
- ✓ Useful in orchards, vineyards and mixed farms.

5. Low Environmental Footprint

- ✓ Sheep emit lower methane emission compared to large ruminants
- ✓ Efficient feed conversion on marginal lands

Regenerative Sheep Rearing Practices

- ✓ Rotational / Managed Grazing
- ✓ Mixed Pasture Systems (grasses + legumes)
- ✓ Minimal Tillage
- ✓ Integration with Cropping Systems
- ✓ Avoidance of Chemical Overuse

Key Message:

Healthy soil → Healthy pasture → Healthy sheep → Sustainable farming



Key Message: Healthy soil → Healthy pasture → Healthy sheep → Sustainable farming.

FieldvetDrMSS

34. Sheep Rearing in Regenerative Farming

Regenerative farming is an agricultural approach that focuses on restoring soil health, biodiversity, and ecosystem balance while producing food sustainably. Sheep play an important role in regenerative systems through grazing, nutrient cycling, and natural pasture management.

What is Regenerative Farming?

Regenerative farming aims to:

- Improve soil organic matter
- Restore ecosystem biodiversity
- Enhance water retention in soils
- Reduce dependence on synthetic inputs

Livestock, particularly sheep, act as biological tools in this system.

Role of Sheep in Regenerative Farming

1 Natural Pasture Management

- Sheep graze selectively on grasses and weeds.
- Prevents overgrowth of undesirable plants.
- Encourages growth of diverse pasture species.

2 Soil Fertility Improvement

- Sheep manure and urine enrich soil with nutrients.
- Enhances nitrogen, phosphorus, and organic matter.
- Improves microbial activity in soil.

3 Weed Control

- Sheep consume many weed species naturally.
- Reduces reliance on herbicides.
- Maintains ecological balance in pasture.

4 Pasture Regeneration

- Controlled grazing stimulates new grass growth.
- Hoof action helps seed incorporation into soil.
- Supports healthy grassland ecosystems.

5 Carbon Sequestration

- Healthy pasture systems store carbon in soil.
- Regenerative grazing helps reduce greenhouse gases.
- Contributes to climate-resilient agriculture.

Key Practices in Regenerative Sheep Farming

- ✓ Rotational grazing
- ✓ Pasture spelling (resting grazing land)
- ✓ Multi-species grazing systems
- ✓ Minimal chemical inputs
- ✓ Maintaining native grass species

Benefits to Farmers

- Improved pasture productivity
- Reduced feed costs
- Healthier sheep flocks
- Sustainable long-term farming
- Better soil and water conservation

Challenges

- Requires careful grazing management
- Initial planning and fencing may be needed
- Farmers need training in regenerative practices

Key Principle

“Healthy soil → Healthy pasture → Healthy sheep → Sustainable farming.”



ETHICAL SHEEP FARMING

Merits and Demerits

*Ethical sheep farming ensures humane treatment, good welfare, environmental sustainability, and **responsible management**.*

FieldvetDrMSS

✓ MERITS



Animal Welfare

- Adequate space & shelter
- Humane handling & care



Better Health & Productivity

- Reduced disease & stress
- Improved growth & quality



Environmental Sustainability

- Controlled grazing
- Soil improvement



Reduced Drug Dependency

- Lower antibiotic use
- Combat AMR



Consumer & Market Benefits

- Higher market value
- Ethical product demand

✗ DEMERITS



Higher Initial Investment

- Costly facilities & care



Lower Stocking Density

- Fewer animals per area
- Reduced profits



Skilled Management Required

- Need for training & monitoring



Certification Challenges

- Complex audits & standards



Market Constraints

- Limited premium markets

Role of the Veterinarian

✓ Welfare Assessment & Planning

✓ Disease Prevention & Biosecurity

✓ Disease Prevention & Biosecurity

✓ Humane Handling & Pain Relief

✓ Humane Handling & Pain Relief

✓ Farmer Education & Advice

Key Message:

*Ethical sheep farming balances animal welfare, farmer livelihood, and **environmental sustainability**.*



FieldvetDrMSS

35. Ethical Sheep Farming-Merits and Demerits

What is Ethical Sheep Farming?

Ethical sheep farming ensures humane treatment, good welfare, environmental sustainability, and responsible management throughout the animal's life cycle.

✓ Merits:

1. Improved Animal Welfare

- Adequate space, shelter, nutrition, and veterinary care
- Humane handling, transport, and slaughter practices

2. Better Health & Productivity

- Lower disease incidence due to stress-free management
- Improved growth, wool quality, and reproductive performance

3. Consumer Trust & Market Value

- Higher demand for ethically produced meat, wool, and milk
- Access to premium markets and certifications

4. Environmental Sustainability

- Controlled grazing reduces land degradation
- Better manure management improves soil health

5. Reduced Use of Antibiotics & Chemicals

- Preventive health care lowers drug dependence
- Helps combat antimicrobial resistance (AMR)

6. Positive Social & Ethical Image

- Aligns with animal rights, One Health, and sustainable agriculture

principles

✗ Demerits:

1. Higher Initial Costs

- Investment in housing, fencing, veterinary care, and trained labor

2. Lower Stocking Density

- Fewer animals per unit area may reduce short-term profitability

3. Increased Management Skill Required

- Requires trained farmers and regular monitoring

4. Certification & Compliance Challenges

- Ethical labelling and audits can be complex and costly

5. Limited Awareness Among Farmers

- Smallholders may lack access to training and resources

6. Market Limitations in Some Regions

- Premium prices not always assured, especially in local markets

□ Role of Veterinarians (Key Point)

- Welfare assessment and health planning
- Humane handling and pain management
- Farmer training on ethical practices
- Disease prevention and biosecurity

STANDARD PARAMETERS FOR REPRODUCTIVE PERFORMANCE OF A SHEEP FARM

1. Estrus & Breeding Parameters

- **Age at Puberty (Ewe)** 6–8 months
- **Breeding Age (Ewe)** 8–10 months
(≥90–70% adult body weight)
- **Estrous Cycle Length** 16–17 days
- **Estrus Duration:** 24–36 hours
- **Breeding Seasonality:** Seasonal breeder (short-day breeder)
- **Ram : Ewe Ratio:**
 - Natural service: 1 : 25–30
 - Young ram: 1 : 15–20



2. Conception & Pregnancy Parameters

- **Conception Rate** – Good farm: 85–90%
- **Excellent farm:** >90%
- **Pregnancy Rate** – 80–90%
- **Gestation Period:** 147–152 days (=150 days)
- **Embryonic Loss:** <5%



2. Conception & Pregnancy Parameters

- **Conception Rate:**
 - Good farm: 85–90%
 - Excellent farm: >90%
- **Pregnancy Rate:** 80–90%
- **Gestation Period:** 147–152 days (=150 days)
- **Embryonic Loss:** <5%



3. Lambing Performance

- **Lambing Interval:** 8–12 months
- **Lambing Rate:**
 - Minimum acceptable: 80%
 - Target: >90%
- **Lambing Percentage:** 120–150%
- **Twinning Rate:**
 - Indigenous breeds: 20–30%
 - Improved breeds: 30–50%
- **Stillbirth Rate:** <3%



4. Lamb Survival & Growth

- **Birth Weight:**
 - Indigenous: 2.0–3.0 kg
 - Crossbred: 3.0–4.0 kg
- **Lambing Percentage:**
 - Average: 120–150%



6. Reproductive Health Indicators

- **Repeat Breeding:** <5%
- **Abortion Rate:** <2%
- **Postpartum Complications:** <5%
- **Infertile Ewes:** <3%



5. Replacement & Flock Turnover

- **Annual Replacement Rate:** 15–20%
- **Culling Rate:** 10–15%
- **Productive Life of Ewe:** 5–7 lambings



7. Ram Fertility Standards

- **Age at First Use:** 10–12 months
- **Breeding Soundness Exam (BSE):** Once/year
- **Libido:** Active: mounts within 5 minutes
- **Scrotal Circumference:**
 - Adult ram: ≥30–34 cm



Importance of Monitoring

- ✓ Improves genetic progress
- ✓ Enhances farm
- ✓ Reduces reproductive wastage
- ✓ Early detection of fertility problems
- ✓ Enhances farm profitability



Veterinary & Animal Science Students



Sheep Farmers & Extension Workers



Competitive Exams: ICAR, PSC, UPSC-ARS

Section 9: Breeding & Reproduction

36. Standard Parameters for Reproductive Performance

Reproductive efficiency is a key indicator of profitability and productivity in sheep farming. Monitoring standard reproductive parameters helps farmers and veterinarians evaluate flock performance and improve lamb production.

Key Reproductive Performance Indicators

Parameter	Standard Value
Age at Puberty	6–8 months
Age at First Mating	8–12 months
Age at First Lambing	12–15 months
Estrous Cycle Length	16–17 days
Duration of Estrus (Heat)	24–36 hours
Gestation Period	147–152 days (Average ~150 days)
Lambing Interval	8–12 months
Lambing Percentage	80–120%
Prolificacy Rate	1.2 – 1.8 lambs per ewe
Conception Rate	85–95%
Weaning Age	60–90 days
Weaning Percentage	75–90%

Important Reproductive Ratios

Ram to Ewe Ratio

1 Ram: 25–35 Ewes (natural mating)

Significance

Ensures efficient breeding and good conception rate

Lambing Rate

- Number of lambs born per 100 ewes mated.
- Good farm standard

- 90–120 lambs per 100 ewes

Lamb Survival Rate

- Percentage of lambs surviving up to weaning.
- Ideal value 85–95%

⚠ Factors Affecting Reproductive Performance

- Nutrition and body condition of ewes
- Breed characteristics
- Health status and disease control
- Ram fertility
- Management practices
- Heat stress and environmental conditions

□ Role of Veterinarians

Veterinarians help improve reproductive performance through:

- Fertility evaluation of rams
- Pregnancy diagnosis
- Control of reproductive diseases
- Nutritional advice
- Proper lambing management

Significance for Sheep Farms

Good reproductive performance leads to:

- Higher lamb crop production
- Better farm profitability
- Faster flock expansion
- Improved genetic progress

✓ Key Message

“Efficient reproduction is the foundation of successful sheep farming.

Monitoring reproductive parameters ensures sustainable flock productivity.”

SHEEP BREEDING SYSTEMS

Crossbreeding vs Pure Breeding



Crossbreeding

Mating of sheep belonging to **two or more different breeds** to combine **desirable traits**.



Pure Breeding

Mating of sheep **within the same breed** to maintain and improve breed characteristics.



Comparison Table

FieldvetDrMSS

Feature	 Crossbreeding	 Pure Breeding
Genetic Basis	 Different breeds	 Same breed
Hybrid Vigor (Heterosis)	 Present	 Absent
Growth Rate	 Higher	 Moderate
Meat Production	 Higher	 Breed-specific
Wool Quality	 Variable, improved in Selected crosses	 Uniform & predictable
Adaptability	 Good (if local genes retained)	 Excellent for native breeds
Disease Resistance	 Improved (heterosis effect)	 Stable but breed-limited
Management Requirement	 High	 Moderate
Uniformity of Offspring	 Variable	 High
Conservation Value	 Low	 Very high
Risk of Genetic Erosion	 High (if uncontrolled)	 Nil



Advantages



Crossbreeding

-  Hybrid vigor
-  Faster growth & early maturity
-  Higher meat yield
-  Better feed efficiency
-  Upgrades indigenous sheep



Disadvantages



Pure Breeding

-  No hybrid vigor
-  Slower genetic improvement
-  Lower productivity in low-yielding breeds
-  Limited scope for rapid meat production



Field-Level Application

FieldvetDrMSS

-  Prefer **Crossbreeding** when:
 - Goal is **commercial** meat production
 - Adequate nutrition & veterinary care available
 - Breeding is **planned** and controlled



Veterinary Recommendation

-  Maintain 50–75% exotic inheritance in crossbreds
-  Avoid indiscriminate crossbreeding
-  Conserve indigenous sheep through purebreeding



KEY MESSAGE

-  Crossbreeding **improves productivity**



37. Sheep Breeding Systems

Sheep breeding systems are organized methods used to improve genetic quality, productivity, and adaptability of sheep flocks. Proper breeding systems help farmers achieve better growth rate, fertility, disease resistance, and meat or wool production.

1. Pure Breeding

Breeding animals within the same breed.

Example: Merino × Merino

Advantages

- Maintains breed purity
- Preserves desirable traits
- Useful for breed conservation

Limitations: Risk of inbreeding if poorly managed

2. Inbreeding

Mating of closely related animals such as:

- Parent × offspring
- Brother × sister

Purpose

- Fix desirable genetic traits
- Produce uniform offspring

Disadvantages

- Reduced fertility
- Increased genetic defects
- Lower disease resistance

3. Line Breeding

A mild form of inbreeding used to maintain traits of a superior ancestor.

Example: breeding animals related to a high-performing ram.

Benefits

- Maintains desirable characteristics
- Reduces severe inbreeding effects

4. Outbreeding (Outcrossing)

Breeding between unrelated animals of the same breed.

Example: unrelated Deccani Sheep animals.

Advantages

- Increases genetic diversity
- Improves vigor and fertility

5 Crossbreeding

Mating animals from two different breeds.

Example: Dorset Sheep × Suffolk Sheep

Benefits

- Hybrid vigor (heterosis)
- Improved growth rate
- Better meat production

6 Grading Up

Improving a local breed by repeated breeding with superior purebred rams.

Example: Local sheep × Rambouillet ram.

After several generations, the flock acquires improved genetic traits.

7 Artificial Insemination (AI)

Use of collected and preserved semen to breed ewes.

Advantages

- Rapid genetic improvement
- Use of superior rams
- Reduced disease transmission

8 Community-Based Breeding

Farmers collectively select superior breeding rams within villages.

Benefits:

- ✓ Maintains indigenous breeds
- ✓ Improves productivity
- ✓ Reduces inbreeding in village flocks

Key Principles of Good Sheep

- Select healthy breeding ram
- Avoid close inbreeding
- Maintain breeding record
- Cull poor performing animal
- Use breeds adapted to local climate

SHEEP CROSSBREEDING

Advantages & Disadvantages



What is Crossbreeding?

Crossbreeding is the mating of sheep from two or more different breeds to combine desirable traits like **growth, meat yield, wool quality, and adaptability**.



FieldvetDrMSS



ADVANTAGES



Hybrid Vigor (Heterosis)

- Faster growth rate
- Higher lamb survival
- Improved fertility



Increased Meat Production

- Better body weight gain
- Improved carcass quality
- Higher feed efficiency



Improved Wool Traits

- Increased fleece weight
- Better fiber quality



Better Adaptability

- Local hardiness + Exotic productivity
- Disease & parasite resistance



Early Maturity

- Early market age
- Shorter production cycle



Upgrading Indigenous Sheep

- Enhances productivity



DISADVANTAGES



Loss of Pure Breed Characteristics

- Genetic dilution
- Loss of local traits



Management Complexity

- Controlled breeding
- Record keeping needed



Inconsistent Performance

- Variable traits in later generations
- Decline in heterosis



Higher Input Requirement

- More nutrition & healthcare



Reduced Adaptability (High Exotic Blood)

- Heat stress
- Disease prone



Poor Availability of Quality Rams

- Few good breeding sires



FIELD MESSAGE



Planned crossbreeding improves productivity



Uncontrolled crossbreeding causes economic loss & genetic erosion

FieldvetDrMSS

VETERINARY RECOMMENDATION



- Maintain 50~75% exotic inheritance
- Use locally adapted crossbred rams
- Conserve indigenous sheep breeds



38. Sheep Crossbreeding - Advantages and Disadvantages

Crossbreeding is the mating of sheep from two or more different breeds to combine desirable traits such as faster growth, better meat production, improved wool quality, or adaptability.

Example:

Dorset Sheep × Suffolk Sheep or Merino × Rambouillet

Advantages of Crossbreeding

1 Hybrid Vigor (Heterosis)

Crossbred lambs often show better growth rate, fertility, and survivability than purebred animals.

2 Improved Meat Production

Crossbreeding can produce faster-growing lambs with better carcass quality.

3 Better Adaptability

Combines hardiness of local breeds with productivity traits of exotic breeds.

Example: Local sheep × Merino to improve wool quality.

4 Higher Reproductive Performance

- Increased lambing percentage.
- Better mothering ability.

5 Genetic Improvement

Introduces new desirable traits into local flocks.

Disadvantages of Crossbreeding

1 Loss of Indigenous Breed Purity

- Continuous crossbreeding may lead to genetic dilution of native breeds.
- Example risk to indigenous breeds such as Nilgiri Sheep.

2 Management Complexity

Requires careful breeding planning and record keeping.

3 Adaptation Problems

Some crossbred animals may not adapt well to local climate or diseases.

4 Variable Offspring

Crossbred lambs may show inconsistent traits.

5 Dependence on Exotic Genetics

Farmers may become dependent on imported breeding stock or semen.

When Crossbreeding is Recommended

Crossbreeding is useful when:

- ✓ Improving meat production
- ✓ Increasing growth rate
- ✓ Improving wool quality
- ✓ Upgrading local breeds

But it must be done scientifically under breeding programmes.

ARTIFICIAL INSEMINATION (AI) IN SHEEP

MERITS & DEMERITS

FieldvetDrMSS

✓ MERITS (Advantages)



1. Genetic Improvement

- Use of superior rams
- Rapid breed improvement



2. Cost Effective (Long Term)

- No need to maintain breeding rams
- Reduced feeding & management cost



3. Disease Control

- Prevents transmission of venereal diseases
- Safer than natural mating



4. Better Breeding Management

- Controlled breeding program
- Planned lambing season



5. Use of Exotic Germplasm

- Access to high-quality semen from distant locations



6. Efficient Use of Elite Rams

- One ram → many ewes

✗ DEMERITS (Limitations)



1. Heat Detection Difficulty

- Silent heat common in sheep
- Requires skilled observation



2. Skilled Labour Required

- Proper AI technique needed
- Trained personnel essential



3. Lower Conception Rate (Field Conditions)

- Especially with frozen semen
- Timing is critical



4. Initial Setup Cost

- Equipment, semen storage (LN₂)
- Infrastructure required



5. Semen Handling Challenges

- Requires strict cold chain maintenance



6. Anatomical Difficulty

- Sheep cervix is complex
- AI is technically difficult



FIELD COMPARISON

Parameter	AI in Sheep
Genetic Gain	High
Cost (Initial)	High
Cost (Long Term)	Low
Skill Requirement	High
Conception Rate	Moderate
Disease Risk	Low



FIELD TIP (#Fieldvet)

- ✓ Perform AI 12–18 hours after onset of estrus
- ✓ Use estrus synchronization for better results
- ✓ Maintain strict hygiene & semen cold chain



#Fieldvet

In the Field, For the Herd.

39. Artificial Insemination (AI) in Sheep

Merits & Demerits

MERITS (Advantages)

1. Genetic Improvement

- Use of superior rams
- Rapid breed improvement

2. Cost Effective (Long Term)

- No need to maintain breeding rams
- Reduced feeding & management cost

3. Disease Control

- Prevents transmission of venereal diseases
- Safer than natural mating

4. Better Breeding Management

- Controlled breeding program
- Planned lambing season

5. Use of Exotic Germplasm

- Access to high-quality semen from distant locations

6. Efficient Use of Elite Rams

- One ram → many ewes

DEMERITS (Limitations)

1. Heat Detection Difficulty

- Silent heat common in sheep
- Requires skilled observation

2. Skilled Labour Required

- Proper AI technique needed
- Trained personnel essential

3. Lower Conception Rate (Field Conditions)

- Especially with frozen semen
- Timing is critical

4. Initial Setup Cost

- Equipment, semen storage (LN₂)
- Infrastructure required

5. Semen Handling Challenges

- Requires strict cold chain maintenance

6. Anatomical Difficulty

- Sheep cervix is complex → AI is technically difficult.

Field Tip

- ✓ Perform AI 12–18 hours after onset of estrus
- ✓ Use estrus synchronization for better results
- ✓ Maintain strict hygiene & semen cold chain

Methods of Castration in Rams

Advantages and Disadvantages

FieldvetDrMSS



1 Surgical Castration (Open Method) (Knife / Scalpel Castration)

♥ Procedure

- Scrotum is incised
- Testes exposed and removed
- Spermatic cord ligated or crushed



Advantages

- ✓ Immediate and complete castration
- ✓ Suitable for older lambs and adult rams
- ✓ Rapid reduction in testosterone
- ✓ Low failure rate

Disadvantages

- ✗ Requires skill and aseptic conditions
- ✗ Risk of bleeding, infection, fly strike
- ✗ Post-operative pain
- ✗ Not ideal in hot or fly season

2 Burdizzo Castration (Bloodless Castration)

✂ Emasculator Method)

- Spermatic cords crushed externally
- Testes left intact but blood supply cut



Advantages

- ✓ No open wound
- ✓ Minimal bleeding
- ✓ Lower risk of infection and fly strike
- ✓ Suitable for field conditions
- ✓ Faster healing than surgical method

Disadvantages

- ✗ Requires proper technique
- ✗ Risk of incomplete castration
- ✗ Testes remain initially (delayed atrophy)
- ✗ Less effective in older rams

3 Elastrator / Rubber Ring Castration

✂ Rubber ring placed at base of Scrotum

- Cuts off blood supply
→ testes slough off

Advantages

- ✓ Simple and inexpensive
- ✓ No bleeding
- ✓ Can be done by farmers
- ✓ Suitable for young lambs (c7-14 days)



- ✗ Faster healing than surgical method

4 Chemical Castration

✂ Injection of sclerosing agents into testes

- No surgery required
- Minimal equipment
- Useful where surgery is not feasible



Diagnoses: Severe pain initially

- ✗ Risk of tetanus Not suitable for older lambs ↔ older Lambs
- ✗ Slow process (takes weeks) Risk of infection if pear

5 Chemical Castration

✂ Injection of sclerosing agents into testes

- No surgery required
- Minimal equipment



Diagnoses: Useful where surgery is not feasible

6 Short Scrotum Castration (Rarely practiced)

✂ Testes pushed upward

- Rubber ring applied below testes

Diagnoses: Incomplete infertility possible

- ✗ Not recommended for breeding control
- ✗ Poor welfare outcomes



Best Age for Castration

- ♥ 7–21 days (rubber ring method preferred)
- Avoid very early castration to reduce risk of urolithiasis
- Delay castration beyond 3 months in feedlot systems

General Advantages of Castration

- Improved meat quality
- Reduced aggression
- Easier management

General Disadvantages of Castration

- Stress and pain
- Risk of infection if poorly managed
- Reduced growth rate if done too early

#Fieldvet

40. Methods of Castration in Rams

Advantages and Disadvantages

1. Surgical Castration (Open Method) (Knife / Scalpel Castration)

Procedure

- Scrotum is incised
- Testes exposed and removed
- Spermatic cord ligated or crushed

Advantages

- Immediate and complete castration
- Suitable for older lambs and adult rams
- Rapid reduction in testosterone
- Effective even in large testes
- Low failure rate

Disadvantages

- Requires skill and aseptic conditions
- Risk of bleeding, infection, fly strike
- Post-operative pain
- Not ideal in hot or fly season
- Requires wound care

2. Burdizzo Castration (Bloodless Castration) (Emasculatome Method)

Procedure

- Spermatic cords crushed externally
- Testes left intact but blood supply cut

Advantages

- No open wound
- Minimal bleeding
- Lower risk of infection and fly strike
- Suitable for field conditions
- Faster healing than surgical method

Disadvantages

- Requires proper technique
- Risk of incomplete castration
- Testes remain initially (delayed atrophy)
- Less effective in older rams
- Pain during crushing

3. Elastrator / Rubber Ring Castration

Procedure

- Rubber ring placed at base of scrotum
- Cuts off blood supply → testes slough off

Advantages

- Simple and inexpensive
- No bleeding
- Can be done by farmers
- Suitable for young lambs (<7–14 days)
- No special equipment needed

Disadvantages

- Severe pain initially
- Risk of tetanus
- Not suitable for older lambs
- Slow process (takes weeks)
- Risk of infection if hygiene poor

4. Chemical Castration

Procedure

- Injection of sclerosing agents into testes

Advantages

- No surgery required
- Minimal equipment
- Useful where surgery is not feasible

Disadvantages

- Inconsistent results
- Risk of tissue necrosis
- Pain and swelling
- Not commonly practiced
- Requires veterinary supervision

5. Short Scrotum Castration (Rarely practiced)

Procedure

- Testes pushed upward
- Rubber ring applied below testes

Advantages

- Reduced testosterone gradually
- Less aggressive behaviour

Disadvantages

- Incomplete infertility possible
- Not recommended for breeding control
- Poor welfare outcomes

Best Age for Castration:

- 7–21 days (rubber ring method preferred)
- Avoid very early castration to reduce risk of urolithiasis
- Delay castration beyond 3 months in feedlot systems

General Advantages of Castration:

- Improved meat quality
- Reduced aggression
- Easier management
- Prevents unwanted breeding
- Better flock uniformity

General Disadvantages of Castration:

- Stress and pain
- Risk of infection if poorly managed
- Reduced growth rate if done too early

Key Message:

□ Choice of castration method depends on age, management system, skill availability, and animal welfare.

Section 10: Farm Management & Evaluation

41. Sheep Body Condition Score (BCS) Guide

SHEEP BODY CONDITION SCORE (BCS) GUIDE #FieldvetDrMSS

Scale: 1 to 5 (with half-scores used in practice)

Assessment Areas:

- Lumbar region (loin eye muscle & backfat)
- Spinous & transverse processes (backbone & ribs)
- Palpation is essential – visual scoring alone is inaccurate

BCS 1 – Emaciated

- **Appearance:**
Sharp, prominent spine
Short ribs very distinct
Loin muscle severely wasted
- **Implications:**
Poor nutrition, illness, heavy parasitism

BCS 2 – Thin

- **Appearance:**
Spine still easily felt
Short ribs palpable with little pressure
Loin muscle flat
- **Implications:**
Below optimum for breeding

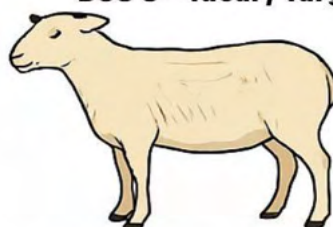
BCS 3 – Ideal / Target

- **Appearance:**
Spine smooth; felt only with pressure
Short ribs smooth, slight padding
Loin muscle full
- **Action:**
Ideal for maintenance, breeding readiness
Recommended BCS for most flock stages

Recommended BCS Ranges by Stage

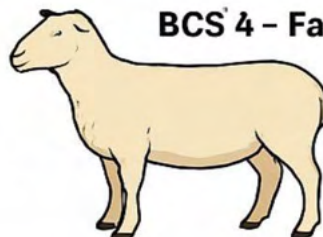
Breeding rams	3.0–3.5
Breeding ewess (mating)	3.0
Mid-pregnancy	2.5–3.0
Late pregnancy	3.0 (avoid >3.5)
Lactation (early)	2.5–3.0
Weaning	2.5–3.0

BCS 3 – Ideal / Target



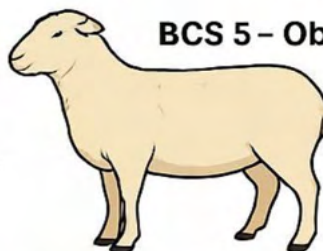
Appearance:
Spine smooth,
felt only with pressure
Short ribs smooth,
slight padding
Loin muscle full

BCS 4 – Fat



Appearance:
Spine difficult to feel
Short ribs rounded
with fat cover
Loin muscle full
with soft fat

BCS 5 – Obese



Appearance:
Spine & ribs
impossible to feel
Excessive fat
around tail head & loin
Loin muscle buried
under fat

How to Score Sheep Accurately



- Score in consistent position: standing, calm, dry sheep
- Score in consistent position: standing, calm, dry sheep

- Always use hands, not eyes alone
- Score along the loin, between the last rib & hip bone
- Feel: use hand to feel Spinous processes Transverse processes Loin muscle depth Fat cover

CHARACTERISTICS OF THE BEST SHEEP FARMER

Science + Skill + Commitment

1 Strong Knowledge & Skills

- ✓ Understands sheep nutrition, breeding, health, and housing
- ✓ Identifies early signs of disease
- ✓ Follows scientific management practices
- ✓ Updates knowledge through training & extension programs

2 Focus on Animal Health & Welfare

- ✓ Regular vaccination and deworming
- ✓ Maintains clean sheds, dry floors & good ventilation
- ✓ Practices biosecurity
- ✓ Ensures stress-free handling

3 Good Feeding & Nutrition Management

- ✓ Balanced ration based on age, physiological status
- ✓ Efficient use of grazing, fodder & crop residues
- ✓ Clean drinking water at all times
- ✓ Mineral mixture supplementation

4 Proper Housing Management

- ✓ Climate-appropriate roof, floor & ventilation
- ✓ Adequate space allowance
- ✓ Proper drainage & waste disposal
- ✓ Separate pens for lambs, pregnant & sick animals

4 Proper Housing Management

- ✓ Climate-appropriate roof, floor & ventilation
- ✓ Adequate space allowance
- ✓ Proper drainage & waste disposal
- ✓ Separate pens for lambs, pregnant & sick animals

5 Record Keeping & Monitoring

- ✓ Maintains records of breeding, health, growth & mortality
- ✓ Tracks expenses and income
- ✓ Uses data for decision-making

5 Record Keeping & Monitoring

- ✓ Maintains records of breeding, health, growth & mortality
- ✓ Tracks expenses and income
- ✓ Uses data for decision-making

6 Breeding & Genetic Improvement Orientation

- ✓ Uses superior breeding rams
- ✓ Avoids inbreeding
- ✓ Selects animals based on performance
- ✓ Culls unproductive animals timely

7 Disease Prevention Oriented

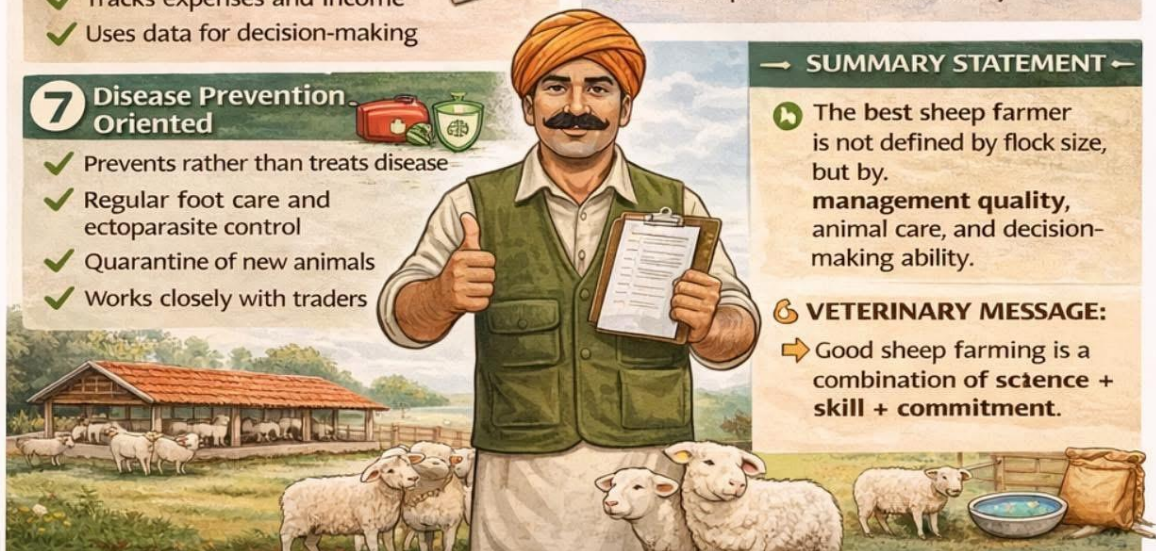
- ✓ Prevents rather than treats disease
- ✓ Regular foot care and ectoparasite control
- ✓ Quarantine of new animals
- ✓ Works closely with traders

SUMMARY STATEMENT

- The best sheep farmer is not defined by flock size, but by **management quality**, animal care, and decision-making ability.

VETERINARY MESSAGE:

- Good sheep farming is a combination of **science + skill + commitment**.



Veterinary Extension | Sheep Farming Success

FieldvetDrMSS

42. Characteristics of the Best Sheep Farmer

Who is a Good Sheep Farmer?

A successful sheep farmer combines knowledge, observation, discipline, and compassion to maintain a healthy, productive, and profitable flock. Good shepherding is both science and skill.

Key Characteristics of the Best Sheep Farmer

Strong Knowledge of Sheep Management

- Understands breeding, nutrition, health, and grazing systems
- Keeps updated with modern sheep farming practices

Excellent Observation Skills

A good farmer observes sheep daily and detects early signs such as:

- Loss of appetite
- Lameness
- Diarrhoea
- Weight loss
- Abnormal behaviour

Early detection prevents major disease outbreaks.

Proper Grazing Management

- Plans rotational grazing
- Protects pasture resources
- Avoids overgrazing
- Healthy pasture = healthy sheep.

Good Animal Health Management

- Follows regular vaccination schedule
- Strategic deworming
- Maintains clean sheds and water
- Works closely with veterinarians.

Record Keeping

Maintains accurate records of:

- Breeding
- Lambing
- Vaccination
- Deworming
- Mortality

- Production

Records help improve farm decisions.

6 Good Breeding Practices

- Selects healthy and productive breeding animals
- Avoids inbreeding
- Focuses on genetic improvement

7 Compassion and Animal Welfare

The best sheep farmers:

- Treat animals with care and patience
- Avoid cruelty and stress
- Ensure adequate feed, water, and shelter

Healthy animals produce better meat, wool, and income.

8 Risk Management Skills

Prepared for: Disease outbreaks, Drought, Market fluctuations

Plans feed reserves and emergency strategies.

9 Financial Discipline

Manages input costs

- Invests wisely in feed, medicines, and breeding stock
- Maintains farm profitability.

10 Continuous Learning

A great sheep farmer:

- Learns from experience
- Attends training programs
- Adopts innovative technologies

🌐 Role of Sheep Farmers in Rural Economy

Sheep farmers contribute to:

- Food security
- Rural employment
- Meat and wool production
- Sustainable grazing systems

📢 Key Message

“Successful Sheep Farming Requires Knowledge, Observation, and Dedication.”

ISO standards ensure quality
production, animal welfare,
food safety & sustainable.



43. ISO Standards Applicable to a Sheep Farm

(ISO does not issue species-specific sheep standards, so farms follow relevant ISO management, welfare, biosecurity, food safety, and environmental standards.)

ISO 9001:2015 – Quality Management System (QMS):

Focus: Farm management & productivity

- ✓ Documented farm SOPs
- ✓ Breeding, feeding & health records
- ✓ Traceability of animals
- ✓ Continuous improvement system

Applied to sheep farm:

- Lambing records
- Mortality & morbidity logs
- Feed procurement records

ISO 22000:2018 – Food Safety Management:

Focus: Meat, milk & wool safety

- ✓ Hazard identification (biological, chemical, physical)
- ✓ Hygienic milking & slaughter practices
- ✓ Feed safety & storage
- ✓ Clean water supply

Applied to sheep farm:

- Clean milking area
- Withdrawal period for drugs
- Safe disposal of carcasses

ISO 14001:2015 – Environmental Management:

Focus: Sustainable sheep farming

- ✓ Waste & manure management
- ✓ Prevention of land degradation
- ✓ Efficient water usage
- ✓ Control of farm pollution

Applied to sheep farm:

- Composting manure
- Controlled grazing
- Effluent management

ISO 45001:2018 – Occupational Health & Safety:

Focus: Worker safety

- ✓ Safe animal handling practices
- ✓ Protection from zoonoses
- ✓ Emergency preparedness
- ✓ PPE usage

Applied to sheep farm:

- Safe shearing procedures
- Vaccination of workers
- Handling aggressive rams

ISO 22005:2007 – Traceability System:

Focus: Animal identification

- ✓ Individual or batch identification
- ✓ Movement records
- ✓ Disease trace-back capability

Applied to sheep farm:

- Ear tagging
- Farm-to-market traceability

ISO 23456 (Guided by OIE / WOA) – Animal Welfare Principles:

(No direct ISO number, but ISO aligns with WOA standards)

- ✓ Freedom from hunger & thirst
- ✓ Freedom from pain & disease
- ✓ Adequate housing & ventilation
- ✓ Humane handling & transport

Applied to sheep farm:

- Proper space allowance
- Shade & shelter
- Pain control during procedures

ISO 17025 – Laboratory Testing (Optional):

Focus: Diagnostic accuracy

- ✓ Feed analysis
- ✓ Water testing
- ✓ Disease diagnostics

 Applied to sheep farm:

- Fodder quality testing
- Water safety testing

□ Key Iso Compliance Practices for Sheep Farms:

- ✓ Biosecurity plan in place
- ✓ Vaccination & deworming schedule
- ✓ Clean housing & drainage
- ✓ Proper record keeping
- ✓ Ethical culling policy

Top message:

“ISO standards ensure quality production, animal welfare, food safety & sustainable sheep farming.”

Sheep Farming vs Goat Farming

Merits & Demerits

FieldvetDrMSS



SHEEP FARMING

MERITS ✓

- ✓ Good for Wool & Meat Production
- ✓ Suited for Open Grazing & Large Flocks
- ✓ Lower Labour Requirement
- ✓ Calm & Easy to Manage
- ✓ Uniform Feeding Habits
- ✓ High Demand for Mutton

DEMERITS ✗

- ✓ Prone to Diseases (PPR, Foot Rot)
- ✓ Poor Browsing Ability
- ✓ Sensitive to Wet Conditions
- ✓ Lower Reproduction Rate
- ✓ Require Predator Protection



GOAT FARMING

MERITS ✓

- ✓ Highly Adaptable to Various Climates
- ✓ High Reproductive Rate
- ✓ Efficient Browsers & Low Cost Feeding
- ✓ Low Investment, Fast Returns
- ✓ High Demand for Chevron
- ✓ Best for Small Farmers

DEMERITS ✗

- ✓ Need Strong Fencing
- ✓ More Labour Intensive
- ✓ Selective & Aggressive
- ✓ Lower Wool Value
- ✓ Higher Skills Required



QUICK COMPARISON

Parameter	Sheep	Goat
Feeding Habit	Grazer	Browser
Reproduction	Mostly Single	Twins/Triplets
Disease Resistance	Lower	Higher
Investment	Moderate	Low
Labour	Less	More
Climate Tolerance	Moderate	High
Suitability	Large Flocks	Small Farmers

WHICH IS BETTER?



For Land-rich & Grazing Areas



For Small Farmers & Quick Income



Mixed Farming (Sheep + Goat)

Choose Based on Your Resources & Goals!



44. Sheep Farming Vs Goat Farming - Merits and Demerits

✓ Sheep Farming: Merits

- Good for wool + meat production (dual purpose in many breeds)
- Better suited to open grazing systems and large flocks
- Lower labour requirement compared to goats
- Calmer temperament – easier flock management
- Uniform feeding behaviour, easier ration planning
- Good market demand for mutton in many regions

✗ Sheep Farming: Demerits

- Highly susceptible to diseases (PPR, enterotoxaemia, foot rot)
- Poor browsing ability – depend mainly on pasture
- Sensitive to wet and humid conditions
- Lower reproductive rate (mostly single lambing)
- Higher mortality under poor management
- Need protection from predators.

✓ Goat Farming: Merits

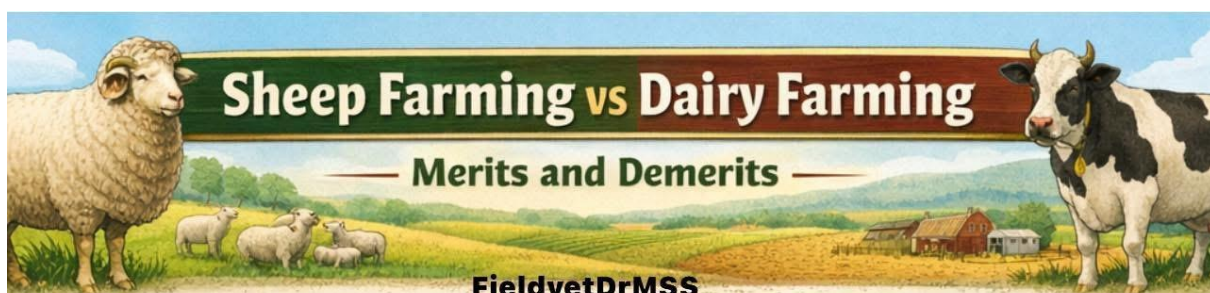
- Excellent adaptability to diverse agro-climatic zones
- High reproductive efficiency (twins/triplets common)
- Efficient browsers – utilize shrubs, weeds, kitchen waste
- Lower initial investment
- Faster return on investment
- High demand for chevon and live goats
- Ideal for small & marginal farmers

✗ Goat Farming: Demerits

- Require better fencing (escape artists!)
- More labour-intensive than sheep
- Selective feeders, nutritional imbalance possible
- Aggressive behaviour in some breeds
- Lower wool value (except specialty breeds)
- Higher management skill required

Which is Better?

- For land-rich farmers & grazing areas → Sheep farming
- For small farmers, dry areas & quick income → Goat farming
- For mixed systems → Sheep + Goat (complementary grazing)



Merits and Demerits

FieldvetDrMSS

Merits & Demerits

Aspect	Sheep Farming 🐑	Dairy Farming 🐄
Initial Investment	✓ Low capital required	✗ High capital (animals, shed)
Land Requirement	✓ Grazing & wastelands	✗ Cultivated fodder land
Feed Cost	✓ Low (grazing-based)	✗ High (fodder & concentrates)
Labour Requirement	✓ Low to moderate	✗ High, skilled labour
Management Complexity	✓ Simple management	✗ Complex (milking, hygiene)
Reproduction Rate	✓ High (twins common)	✗ Low (one calf/yr)
Income Pattern	✗ Seasonal income	✓ Daily income (milk)
Market Risk	✗ Price fluctuation	✓ Milk price instability
Disease Risk	✗ High parasitic diseases	✓ High metabolic diseases
Climate Adaptability	✓ Highly adaptable	✗ Heat sensitive
Value-Added Products	✓ Limited	✗ High (curd, ghee, paneer)
Government Support	✗ Limited support	✓ Strong support
Manure Value	✗ Low	✓ High (biogas, organic)
Profitability (Small Scale)	✓ Good for marginal farmers	✗ Challenging without scale

Merits

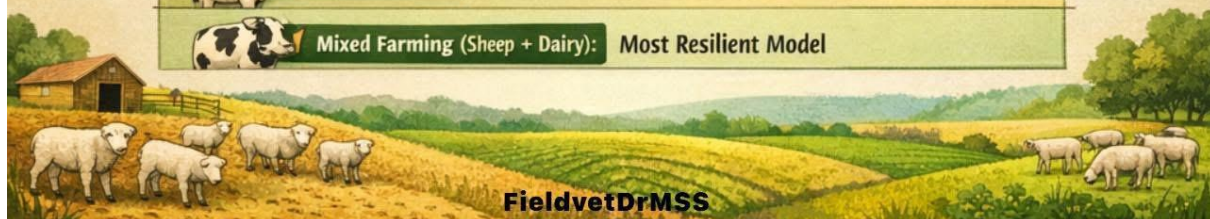
Sheep Farming Merits	Dairy Farming Merits
 Low Investment	 Daily Income
 Thrives on Wastelands	 Daily Income
 Quick Returns	 Daily Income
 Dryland Adaptable	

Demerits

Sheep Farming Demerits	Dairy Farming Demerits
 Seasonal Income	 High Feed Cost
 High Disease Risk	 Labour Intensive
 Lamb Mortality	 Heat Stress
 Limited Support	 Technical Know how

Field-Level Conclusion

	Sheep Farming: Best for Dryland & Marginal Farmers
	Dairy Farming: Best for Farmers with Fodder Access
	Mixed Farming (Sheep + Dairy): Most Resilient Model



FieldvetDrMSS

45. 🐑 Sheep Farming vs 🐄 Dairy Farming

(Comparative Educational Content for Farmers & Veterinary Students)

Sheep farming and dairy farming are two important livestock enterprises. Each system differs in investment, management, land requirement, and income patterns.

📌 Primary Production Objective

Sheep Farming

- Meat production (mutton/lamb)
- Wool production
- Manure for agriculture

Dairy Farming

- Milk production
- Milk products (curd, butter, cheese, ghee)
- Manure and draft power (in some systems)

📌 Initial Investment

Sheep Farming

- Relatively low investment
- Simple housing structures
- Low-cost feeding systems

Dairy Farming

- High investment
- Costly animals
- Infrastructure for milking, housing, and feed storage

📌 Land Requirement

Sheep Farming

- Requires grazing land or pasture
- Suitable for dryland and semi-arid regions

Dairy Farming

- Requires land for fodder cultivation
- Stall feeding systems common

📌 Feed Requirement

Sheep Farming

- Mainly grazing-based feeding
- Crop residues and pasture grasses

Dairy Farming

- Requires high-quality fodder
- Concentrate feed essential for milk production

5 Labour Requirement

Sheep Farming

- Low labour requirement
- One shepherd can manage large flocks

Dairy Farming

- High labour requirement
- Milking twice daily
- Intensive daily management

6 Reproductive Rate

Sheep Farming

- Faster multiplication
- Twins common in many breeds
- Shorter generation interval

Dairy Farming

- One calf per year typically
- Slower herd expansion

7 Income Pattern

Sheep Farming

- Income mainly during sale of lambs or adult sheep
- Seasonal or periodic income

Dairy Farming

- Daily income through milk sales
- Continuous cash flow

8 Disease Risk

Sheep Farming

- Parasitic diseases common
- Outbreaks like PPR, sheep pox

Dairy Farming

- Mastitis

- Reproductive disorders
- Metabolic diseases

9 Adaptability

Sheep Farming

- Highly adaptable to harsh environments
- Suitable for drought-prone regions

Dairy Farming

- Requires good nutrition and management
- More sensitive to environmental stress

10 Profitability

Sheep Farming

- ✓ Lower investment
- ✓ Lower risk in dry areas
- ✓ Good for small farmers and pastoralists

Dairy Farming

- ✓ Regular income
- ✓ High returns with proper management
- ✓ Suitable near urban markets

Key Takeaway

Aspect	Sheep Farming	Dairy Farming
Investment	Low	High
Labour	Low	High
Income	Seasonal	Daily
Feed	Grazing	Stall feeding
Adaptability	High	Moderate

Conclusion

Both systems are valuable. The choice depends on land availability, climate, investment, capacity, and market access.

Ornamental Sheep Management

For hobby farms, exhibitions, parks & educational units.



Jacob • Dorper (ornamental) • Racka • Valais Blacknose • Quessant • Quessant

1 Breed Selection

- ✓ Jacob, Dorper (ornamental), Racka, Valais Blacknose, Quessant
- ✓ Docile & distinctive breeds



2 Housing & Environment

- ✓ Clean, ventilated shelter
- ✓ Shade & secure fencing

1.2–1.5 m² per sheep



3 Feeding & Nutrition

- ✓ Quality fodder & clean water
- ✓ Minerals & salt lick

BCS: 2.5–3.0 Ideal



4 Grooming & Appearance

- ✓ Regular Shearing & Hoof Trimming
- ✓ Wool Cleaning & Parasite Control



★ Show Ready!

5 Health Management

- ✓ Vaccination & Deworming
- ✓ Check Lameness, Appetite, Coat
- ✓ Quarantine New Animals



6 Reproduction & Breeding

- ✓ Controlled Breeding
- ✓ Avoid Inbreeding
- ✓ Lambing Supervision



7 Behaviour & Handling

- ✓ Gentle & Calm Handling
- ✓ Tame from a young age
- ✓ Avoid Stress



9 Exhibition & Transport

- ✓ Health Checks & Soft Bedding
- ✓ No Overcrowding
- ✓ Post-Event Care



10 Record Keeping

- ✓ Health & Grooming Logs
- ✓ Breeding Records
- ✓ Feed & Expenses



Healthy Sheep + Clean Coat + Calm Temperament = Successful
Ornamental Sheep Management

FieldvetDrMSS

46. Ornamental Sheep Management

Ornamental sheep are maintained mainly for aesthetic value, exhibition, breeding, and educational purposes, rather than meat or wool production. Management focuses on appearance, health, temperament, and welfare.

Breed Selection

Choose breeds known for distinct looks and calm nature:

- Jacob sheep – multi-horned, spotted coat
- Dorper (ornamental lines) – sleek appearance
- Racka – spiral horns
- Valais Blacknose – fluffy, attractive face
- Ouessant – miniature sheep

✓ Prefer docile, disease-resistant, climate-adapted breeds.

Housing & Environment

- Clean, dry, well-ventilated sheds
- Shade and protection from rain, wind, and extreme heat
- Non-slippery flooring (rubber mats or dry bedding)
- Adequate space:
- Adult sheep: 1.2–1.5 m²/head
- Secure fencing (ornamental sheep are often curious!)

Feeding & Nutrition

- Good-quality green fodder (legumes + grasses)
- Clean drinking water at all times
- Limited concentrate feed (excess causes obesity)
- Mineral mixture + salt lick
- Avoid sudden diet changes (prevents digestive upset)

□ Body condition score (BCS): 2.5–3.0 ideal

Grooming & Appearance Care (Key Area)

- Regular shearing or coat trimming
- Wool washing before shows/exhibitions
- Hoof trimming every 6–8 weeks
- Horn cleaning (if present)
- External parasite control for clean coat

 Appearance = value in ornamental sheep

Health Management

- Routine vaccination (as per regional schedule)
- Regular deworming (based on fecal egg count)
- Control ectoparasites (ticks, lice, mites)
- Observe daily for: Lameness, Loss of appetite, Dull coat, Nasal discharge

Quarantine new animals for 2–3 weeks

Reproduction & Breeding

- Controlled breeding to maintain aesthetic traits
- Avoid inbreeding
- Maintain breeding records
- Lambing supervision essential (ornamental breeds may need assistance)

Behaviour & Handling

- Gentle handling from young age
- Human interaction improves temperament
- Avoid rough handling (stress affects appearance & health)

Biosecurity & Welfare

- Footbaths at entry points
- Regular cleaning & disinfection
- Fly control around sheds
- Follow animal welfare standards (no over-grooming or cosmetic harm)

Exhibition & Transport Care

- Health check before transport
- Clean crates with soft bedding
- Avoid overcrowding
- Post-event observation for stress or infections

10 Record Keeping

Maintain records for:

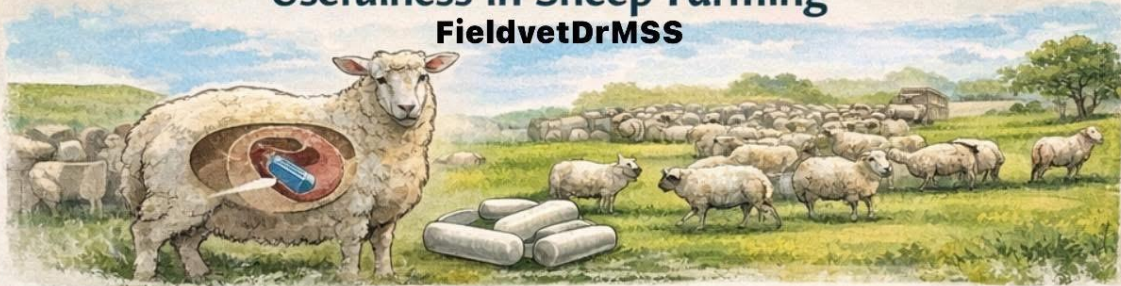
- Health treatments
- Grooming schedules
- Breeding & lambing
- Feed & expenses

Key Goal

Healthy sheep + clean coat + calm temperament = successful ornamental sheep management.

RUMEN-RETAINED CERAMIC BOLUSES

Usefulness in Sheep Farming FieldvetDrMSS



What Are Rumen-Retained Ceramic Boluses?

Rumen-retained ceramic boluses are dense, heavy oral devices designed to remain in the rumen-reticulum and release minerals, trace elements, or monitoring signals over an extended period.

- ✓ Made of inert ceramic material.
- ✓ Resistant to rumination and regurgitation
- ✓ Long-term action (weeks to months)



How Do They Work?

- ✓ Administered orally using a balling gun
- ✓ High density ($> 2.5 \text{ g/cm}^3$) ensures rumen retention
- ✓ Slowly releases nutrients and continuously transmits data.
- ✓ Eliminates need for frequent supplementation



Types of Ceramic Boluses Used in Sheep

1 Nutrient Supplementation Boluses

- ✓ Trace minerals:
- ✓ Selenium (Se)
- ✓ Copper (Cu) (breed-sensitive)
- ✓ Cobalt (Co)
- ✓ Iodine (I)
- ✓ Zinc (Zn)
- ✓ Vitamin-mineral combinations



Usefulness in Sheep Farming.

1 Prevention of Trace Mineral Deficiencies

- ✓ Reduces: White muscle disease (Se-deficiency)
- ✓ Poor wool quality
- ✓ Reproductive failure
- ✓ Poor growth rates



Important Precautions

- Copper boluses **NOT** recommended
- Highly copper-sensitive breeds (e.g., certain indigenous sheep)
- Always assess Soil & fodder mineral status
- Breed susceptibility



23 Smart / Sensor Boluses (Advanced Farms)

- ✓ Measure:
- ✓ Rumen temperature
- ✓ Rumen pH
- ✓ Activity patterns

Used for early disease detection:



2 Reproductive Benefits

- ✓ Improves estrus expression
- ✓ Conception rates
- ✓ Lamb viability
- ✓ Reduces embryonic losses



4 Reduced Labour & Handling Stress

- ✓ Single administration lasts 3–12 months
- ✓ Avoids repeated injections or drenches
- ✓ Minimizes stress & handling injuries



Administration Guidelines

- ✓ Administer only to sheep $> 20\text{--}25 \text{ kg}$ body weight
- ✓ Use proper balling gun
- ✓ Ensure correct placement.
- ✓ Avoid use in weak, sick or heavily pregnant sheep (tine gestation)



Animal HEALTH MESSAGE: — Rumen-retained ceramic boluses provide precise, long-term mineral nutrition with minimal stress – when used correctly.

47. Rumen-Retained Ceramic Boluses

What Are Rumen-Retained Ceramic Boluses?

Rumen-retained ceramic boluses are dense, heavy oral devices designed to remain in the rumen–reticulum of sheep and release minerals, trace elements, or monitoring signals over an extended period.

- ✓ Made of inert ceramic material
- ✓ Resistant to rumination and regurgitation
- ✓ Long-term action (weeks to months)

How Do They Work?

- Administered orally using a balling gun
- High density ($> 2.5 \text{ g/cm}^3$) ensures rumen retention
- Slowly releases nutrients or continuously transmits data
- Eliminates need for frequent supplementation

Types of Ceramic Boluses Used in Sheep

Nutrient Supplementation Boluses

Trace minerals:

- Selenium (Se)
- Copper (Cu) (breed-sensitive)
- Cobalt (Co)
- Iodine (I)
- Zinc (Zn)
- Vitamin-mineral combinations

Smart / Sensor Boluses (Advanced Farms)

Measure:

- Rumen temperature
- Rumen pH
- Activity patterns
- Used for early disease detection

Usefulness in Sheep Farming

1. Prevention of Trace Mineral Deficiencies

Reduces:

- White muscle disease (Se deficiency)
- Poor wool quality
- Reproductive failure

- Poor growth rates
- ✓ Especially useful in mineral-deficient grazing areas

□ 2. Improved Growth & Productivity

- Sustained mineral supply
- Better feed utilization
- Improved lamb growth
- Enhanced wool yield & quality

□ 3. Reproductive Benefits

Improves:

- Estrus expression
- Conception rates
- Lamb viability
- Reduces embryonic losses

□ 4. Reduced Labour & Handling Stress

- Single administration lasts 3–12 months
- Avoids repeated injections or drenches
- Minimizes stress & handling injuries

□ 5. Health Monitoring & Early Disease Detection (Smart Boluses)

Early detection of:

- Ruminal acidosis
- Fever / infection
- Heat stress
- Enables precision livestock farming

Important Precautions

Copper boluses NOT recommended for:

- Highly copper-sensitive breeds (e.g., certain indigenous sheep)

✓ Always assess:

- Soil & fodder mineral status
- Breed susceptibility
- Existing supplementation

□ **Administration Guidelines**

- Administer only to sheep > 20–25 kg body weight
- Use proper balling gun

- Ensure correct placement
- Avoid use in: Weak, sick, or heavily pregnant sheep (late gestation)

Limitations

- Higher initial cost
- Risk of mineral toxicity if misused

Smart boluses require:

- Infrastructure
- Data management systems

Animal Health Message

Rumen-retained ceramic boluses provide precise, long-term mineral nutrition with minimal stress—when used correctly.

Key Takeaway

Right mineral + right breed + right dose = healthier, more productive sheep

Conclusion: The Future of Sustainable Ovine Management

1. Synthesizing Tradition and Technology

The journey of sheep farming is transitioning from a traditional survival activity to a scientifically managed enterprise. The success of this transition lies in the delicate balance between honouring the time-tested wisdom of pastoralist communities and embracing modern veterinary interventions. By utilizing data-driven insights—from genetic selection of indigenous breeds like the Vembur to AI-assisted disease surveillance—we can ensure a resilient livestock sector.

2. The Imperative of Preventative Care

As outlined in this guide, the mantra for the modern shepherd and veterinarian must be "Prevention over Cure." Systematic vaccination, strategic deworming, and nutritional security are not just clinical requirements; they are the economic safeguards of a farm's profitability. Reducing mortality and improving the "Average Daily Gain" (ADG) of lambs are the most direct routes to the socio-economic upliftment of rural households.

3. Commitment to the "One Health" Vision

Our responsibility extends beyond the farm gate. By maintaining the health of our sheep, we are actively participating in a global One Health mission. Preventing zoonotic spillovers, reducing the misuse of antibiotics to combat antimicrobial resistance (AMR), and protecting our communal rangelands are essential steps toward a healthier planet for animals and humans alike.

4. A Call to Action for Stakeholders

The transformation of the sheep industry requires a collaborative effort:

- **For Veterinarians:** To serve as proactive mentors and first responders in the field.
- **For Farmers:** To adopt scientific housing, breeding, and record-keeping practices.
- **For Policy Makers:** To protect migratory corridors and support the conservation of our precious indigenous germplasm.

Closing Statement

"The strength of the flock is the shepherd, and the strength of the shepherd is the science that guides them. May this guide serve as a roadmap toward a future where every sheep is healthy, every farmer is prosperous, and our indigenous heritage is preserved for generations to come."